

Sd/- Chief Engineer, PWD (Building) Chief Engineer, PWD (Building) Asam, Chandmari, Guwahati-3.	should bring with them copy of the I-card of their ward/children(s) also. Only school society members are allowed. ARUN GHOSAL (Chairman) Bengali Senior Secondary School Society Dated the 11th June 2026
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CM Gupta presents Viksit Delhi vision at 11th NITI Aayog meet

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Thursday presented her vision on the development of the national capital and Delhi's role in building 'Viksit Bharat@2047' at the 11th NITI Aayog Governing Council meeting, chaired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

The Chief Minister presented before the nation a detailed account of the transformative schemes being implemented by the Delhi Government in the fields of education, health-care, infrastructure and social welfare, and stated that her Government is making continuous and serious efforts to build a 'Viksit Delhi'.

Sharing details, the chief ministers' office said in a press statement that the Chief Minister said that the identity of a developed nation is determined not

only by economic or technological development, but also by the capability and productivity of its citizens. She underlined that Delhi has emerged as a strong engine driving the country's transformation.

On finances, the Chief Minister stated that Delhi receives neither a share in taxes nor grants from the Finance Commission and requested that Central assistance be increased to match what other states receive.

She also sought early reconciliation and release of the remaining balance in Delhi's Public Account, which was separated from the Central Government accounts in 2025.

On infrastructure, she noted that road infrastructure worth nearly ₹1 lakh crore is being developed in Delhi with Central support and that the Delhi Metro network has reached nearly 500 kilometres.

On women's empowerment, the Chief Minister announced the Delhi Lakhpati Bitiya Yojana, under which ₹1 lakh will be deposited into a girl's account when she turns 18 and meets the prescribed criteria. Free bicycles will be provided to girls in Government schools to reduce dropout rates in Class 9. The Saheli Pink Card has been launched to replace paper tickets and provide free travel for women and transgender persons. Women have also been permitted to work night shifts to increase workforce participation. Mahila Haat Outlets, called Rani Haat, will be launched as permanent marketing platforms for products made by women from shelter homes and self-help groups.

On education, more than 8,777 smart classrooms have been set up in Government schools. In the past year, 125

digital libraries, 175 computer laboratories, and 125 language laboratories were established.

Artificial Intelligence is being integrated into assessment systems and personalised learning pathways from this year. Under the NEEV programme, financial assistance of ₹20,000 was provided to each innovation team for students from Classes 8 to 12, benefiting more than 4,800 students. Seventy-five CM Shri Schools were established during 2025-26.

On healthcare, Delhi's first Brain Health Clinic has been set up in Dwarka. Free MRI and CT scan facilities under a PPP model are being extended to all Government hospitals. One hundred and fifty dialysis centres are already operational. A total of 370 Ayushman Arogya Mandirs are functional, with a target to add 750 more this year.

Hindi Academy renames literary awards after nationalist leaders, freedom fighters

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government's Hindi Academy has renamed its various literary awards after prominent nationalist leaders and freedom fighters, including Vinayak Damodar Savarkar, Deen Dayal Upadhyay, and Madan Mohan Malviya.

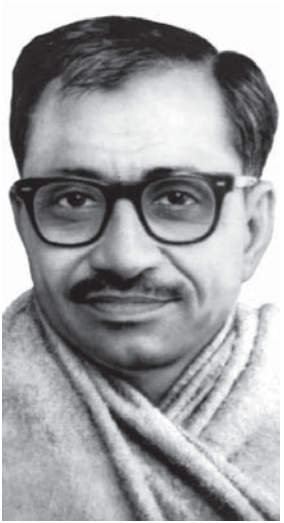
The academy has instituted a new category of award for promotion of Indian Culture and Knowledge Tradition, named after former Prime Minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee. An award has been initiated in the name of the late Vijay Kumar Malhotra, a BJP veteran who passed away last September, for those dedicated to the service of Hindi.

The Hindi Academy has invited applications for various award categories for the 2022-23, 2023-24, 2024-25, and 2025-26 academic years. Eligible litterateurs, poets, and journalists based in the National Capital Region (NCR)-Delhi must submit their entries by June 23, officials said.

Under the 'Sahityakar Samman Yojna' of the academy, sixteen categories of awards carrying cash prizes will be provided to Hindi litterateurs, poets and journalists who have worked



Vinayak Damodar Savarkar



Deen Dayal Upadhyay



Madan Mohan Malviya

for promotion of the national language, said the official.

Hindi Academy Shalaka Samman now rechristened as Pandit Deen Dayal Upadhyay Shalaka Samman will carry a cash prize of ₹7 lakh which was ₹5 lakh earlier. 'Atal Bihari Vajpayee Bhartiya Sanskriti and Gyan Parampara Samman' will have a cash reward of ₹5 lakh.

Rani Ahilyabai Holkar Samman (for women litterateurs), Sant Ravidas Sahitya Samman, Veer Savarkar Samman for national consciousness, will carry cash prize of ₹2 lakh each.

The award for women lit-

terateurs was earlier named after Santosh Koli, an anti-corruption activist who died in a road accident. The previous AAP Government in Delhi named the award in her memory.

Other categories of the awards include Pandit Madan Mohan Malviya Hindi Sahityakar Samman, Baba Jorawar Singh Samman (children literature), Swami Vivekanad Yuva Pratibha Samman, with reward of Rs one lakh each.

Both the Hindi journalism award (Vidya Niwas Mishra Samman) and the Dr Vijay Kumar Malhotra Hindi Sevi Samman for the promo-

tion of the Hindi language carry cash prizes of ₹1 lakh each. The details of the awards have been uploaded on the academy's website.

The awards also include Nirmal Verma Samman for Hindi translation, Ramchandra Shukla Hindi Utkarsh Samman, Vasudev Sharan Agrawal Samman for folk writings, Devendra Swaroop Samman for writings in science, economics, political science, history, sociology and other subjects, Mridula Sinha Samman for women litterateurs and Narendra Kohli Samman for writings in various forms of literature.

DDA to plant 23 lakh native saplings across 1,000 acres in Capital

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Development Authority has launched a mega plantation drive that will see nearly 23 lakh native saplings planted across approximately 1,000 acres of land in Delhi, covering 675 DDA parks, four Ridge areas, six biodiversity parks, and multiple green corridors. The plantation activities are scheduled to begin in the first week of July and continue through mid-September 2026, at the direction of Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu.

The 1,000 acres targeted under the programme is equivalent to nearly four square kilometres and represents approximately 2.9 percent of Delhi's total geographical area. The saplings to be planted comprise trees, shrubs, and bushes, all selected from native and climate-resilient species suited to Delhi's ecological conditions.



The LG has said his office will personally monitor the plantation drive as it progresses. The initiative was directed following a review meeting held by the LG in May.

The four Ridge areas to be covered under the drive are the South Central Ridge, Nanakpura Ridge, Central Ridge, and Northern Ridge.

In addition to the Ridge and the 675 parks, the programme will cover Yamuna floodplain areas, urban forests, roadside and drain-side green corridors, institutional and community green spaces, and identified inter-

vention zones within the city's biodiversity parks.

The selection of native species is central to the programme's design. DDA said native and climate-resilient species offer stronger biodiversity value, greater carbon sequestration potential, better microclimatic regulation, and improved ecological connectivity across the city's green systems. The drive is expected to contribute to air quality improvement, groundwater recharge, habitat creation, and overall urban liveability.

Preparatory work is already

underway. This includes site identification and demarcation, soil preparation and pit digging, development of irrigation arrangements, species selection based on ecological suitability, strengthening of nursery stocks, and logistical planning. Maintenance and monitoring mechanisms are also being put in place to ensure the long-term survival and effective upkeep of the planted saplings.

The LG has been consistently emphasising the enhancement of Delhi's green cover, ecological restoration, and environmental sustainability. The plantation drive reflects a focus on protecting and restoring the Ridge ecosystem, which serves as the city's green lungs and plays a critical role in regulating Delhi's urban climate.

The Aravalli landscapes and Yamuna floodplain areas have been identified for focused interventions given their ecological significance.

The programme is part of

DDA's broader objective of creating interconnected ecological networks across the capital through landscape restoration and urban afforestation. The authority said the initiative is aimed at building Delhi's long-term climate resilience and improving air quality, which has been a persistent concern in the capital across seasons.

Delhi has seen significant green cover loss over the decades due to rapid urbanisation, construction, and encroachment on forest and Ridge land. The plantation of 23 lakh saplings in a single season, if successfully executed and maintained, would represent one of the larger urban afforestation exercises the city has undertaken in recent years.

DDA said it remains committed to enhancing Delhi's ecological infrastructure through sustained afforestation and landscape restoration efforts for present and future generations.

7 shots, shattered glass: Guru Randhawa's gym targeted; Bishnoi Gang claims responsibility

KHUSHI MEHROTRA
■ New Delhi

Two motorcycle-borne assailants allegedly opened fire at a gym in Delhi's Paschim Vihar area early on Thursday, shattering its glass facade and triggering a police investigation into possible extortion and gang-related motives. No injuries were reported in the incident.

According to police, a PCR call was received at the Paschim Vihar East police station in the early hours of June 11 regarding a firing incident at the "24 Hs Fitness" gym in Pushkar Enclave. Preliminary inquiries revealed that two unidentified men, who had covered their faces with cloth, arrived on a motorcycle, fired multiple rounds at the gym, and then fled the scene.

Police said at least seven rounds were fired at the



gym's glass frontage around 4 am. Caretakers discovered the incident about an hour later, when they arrived at the fitness centre, and informed the police.

Two residents of Rajouri Garden reportedly own the gym and have popular Punjabi singer Guru Randhawa as its brand ambassador.

A police team rushed to the scene and found that the bullets had struck the gym's glass panels. No one was inside the premises at the

time of the attack, and no injuries were reported.

Officials said local and district police have launched a probe and formed multiple teams to identify and apprehend the accused. Forensic experts examined the crime scene and are scrutinising CCTV footage from nearby areas to track the attackers' movements.

Soon after the firing, a social media post surfaced in which jailed gangster Lawrence Bishnoi's gang claimed responsibility.

The Pioneer found that a profile named Anil Pandit of the Bishnoi gang allegedly claimed responsibility for the attack. In the Facebook post, Pandit noted that the gang attacked Randhawa's gym because he was getting "too close" to actor Salman Khan. The post further mentioned that they had "warned" Randhawa about this in the past.

Delhi police concludes 22nd self-defence summer camp; over 2,100 women trained



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police's Special Police Unit for Women and Children concluded its 22nd Self-Defence Summer Camp on Thursday with closing ceremonies held simultaneously at four venues across the city, where more than 2,100 girls and women who completed the 14-day training programme received certificates and demonstrated the self-defence skills they had acquired over the course of the camp.

The camp ran from May 29 to June 11, 2026. The closing ceremony at all four venues was attended by senior SPUWAC officers, including Joint Commissioner of Police Nabam Gungete, Additional Commissioner of Police Deotosh Kumar Surendra Singh, Deputy Commissioner of Police Neha Yadav, and Additional Deputy Commissioner of Police Dr Ridhima Seth. The officers attended the ceremonies at different venues and interacted with the participants.

During the camp, participants received training in self-defence techniques and

were sensitised on issues related to women's safety, cyber safety, legal awareness, personality development, mental health, and other life skills. Educational, recreational, and fitness activities were also conducted throughout the duration of the camp.

At the closing ceremonies, participants gave self-defence demonstrations and presented cultural activities that showcased the skills they had developed during the training. Certificates were distributed to all participants on successful completion of the programme. Saplings were also given to participants to promote environmental awareness and encourage plantation activities.

Addressing the participants, the senior officers praised the enthusiasm and dedication shown by the campers and encouraged them to remain confident, aware, and self-reliant in their daily lives. They emphasised that self-defence is not only a practical tool for personal safety but also an effective means of building confidence and a sense of empowerment among women and girls.

Police busts fake helicopter booking syndicate

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A BTech student from Uttar Pradesh's Jaunpur who built and managed fake helicopter booking websites, two associates who handled the financial operations from Bihar's Nalanda, and a network of fraudulent travel portals disguised as legitimate booking platforms targeting pilgrims and tourists: Delhi Police's Cyber Police Station of South District has arrested three members of an interstate cyber fraud syndicate linked to nearly 30 complaints across multiple states and Union Territories involving a total cheating amount of approximately ₹10 lakh.

The three arrested are



Omprakash Kumar and Rohit Kumar, both from Nalanda in Bihar, and Shreyansh Tiwari alias Shivam, a resident of Jaunpur in Uttar Pradesh and a BTech student, who was arrested from Greater Noida. Tiwari is identified by police as the architect of the operation, the person who built and maintained the

fake websites and ran their digital advertising.

The syndicate operated two fraudulent websites: irctc-helicopter.com and irctc-helijatra.com. Both were designed to closely resemble legitimate travel booking portals. The names deliberately incorporated the IRCTC brand to give the sites an appearance of

official affiliation.

The sites were promoted through paid advertisements on Meta platforms, including Facebook, targeting users who searched online for helicopter booking services for religious pilgrimages and tourist destinations.

The chain worked in layers. A victim searching for helicopter bookings would encounter the advertisements, land on one of the fake sites, and make an initial payment.

After that first payment, the victims were subjected to further pressure: additional transfers were demanded under fabricated pretexts such as processing refunds, confirming bookings, or paying registration charges.

Armed men attack Azadpur metro pub with sticks at midnight

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A group of unidentified men arrived by car at the DOT Club, a pub operating inside the Azadpur Metro Rail Station premises in north-west Delhi, around midnight on the intervening night of Wednesday and Thursday, and attacked the establishment with sticks and scythes, damaging property inside the premises before fleeing the spot, police said.

The club owner, Om Singh, informed police that several persons reached the location in a vehicle, entered the pub, and caused extensive damage to prop-



erty using sticks and scythes. The attack was swift. By the time a police team reached the location after receiving information, all the accused had already left the area.

An FIR has been registered at Azadpur Metro Police Station under rele-

vant sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita. Police have examined CCTV footage from the area and said they have identified some of the suspects involved in the attack. Efforts are underway to trace and apprehend them. The motive behind the

attack has not yet been ascertained and is being investigated.

The attack carries several details that investigators will be focusing on. The choice of weapons, sticks and scythes, and the arrival by car suggest a group that came to the location specifically to target the establishment rather than an incident that escalated from a situation already inside the pub.

The timing, around midnight, and the speed with which the group entered, caused damage, and left before police could reach the spot, indicate some degree of prior planning in the execution of the attack.

Inspection drive flags hotels, coaching centres and commercial units

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A wide-ranging enforcement and inspection drive carried out by district authorities across Delhi on Thursday uncovered multiple alleged violations related to fire safety norms, building regulations, and unauthorized construction at hotels, coaching centres, commercial establishments, and residential properties, according to an official daily inspection report. The inspections were concentrated in several key locations, with New Usmanpur, Khajuri Khas, Brijpuri, Shahdara, Narela, and Daryapur Kalan emerging as major areas where authorities detected violations and initiated action.

In North East Delhi district, officials inspected a series of establishments in Yamuna Vihar, Shahdara and Karawal Nagar subdivisions. The inspection report shows that several properties were found operating without fire safety clearances and were issued show-cause notices.



Gym owner shot dead in Haryana’s Hansi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Hansi/New Delhi

A 25-year-old gym owner and fitness trainer, Kapil Redhu, was shot dead near Fawwara Chowk in Hansi on Thursday morning during an outdoor exercise session with clients, in an attack captured on CCTV. Two motorcycle-borne assailants carried out the shooting. The Lawrence Bishnoi gang has claimed responsibility via a social media post and an audio message purportedly from gangster Hari Boxer.

At around 5:30 am, Redhu, who ran the Red Gym, was supervising a group of young men and women during their morning warm-up on the steps outside shops near Fawwara Chowk. Two assailants arrived on a motorcycle, reportedly a Hero Splendour. One of them, wearing a helmet or mask, opened fire from close range, pumping around 10 rounds into Redhu in a

matter of seconds. Redhu sustained multiple gunshot wounds, including to the head and back, and collapsed on the spot. He was rushed to a hospital but was declared dead on arrival.

A woman trainee, identified as Shikha, who was warming up nearby, sustained pellet injuries from bullet fragments and was admitted to a private hospital in Hisar. Police said she was not the intended target. The attack sent the other trainees fleeing for cover.

The assailants fled the scene immediately after the shooting. Hours after the murder, a social media post and an audio message surfaced in which a person identifying himself as Hari Boxer of the Lawrence Bishnoi gang claimed responsibility. The message stated: "I am Hari Boxer from the Lawrence Bishnoi gang. The murder of Kapil, the Red Gym operator in Hansi, was carried out by us. I, RD Dhalwal, Harman Sandhu



and Vikram Kadhal take responsibility for it."

The post said Redhu had been involved in recent shootouts in Shekhpura and Dhani Purnia/Puriya areas and claimed he had ignored prior warnings issued through an associate. It warned that other alleged conspirators would face similar consequences.

Police are verifying the

authenticity of the claim and the post. Kapil Redhu, a resident of Dalmwala village in Jind district, had been running his gym in Hansi for nearly three years. He had recently shifted the facility to a new location near Krantikari Chowk and was living in the Shanti Niketan area of the town. He was his parents' only son, and had had an isolemnised love

marriage about a year ago; his wife was reportedly staying with her parents at the time.

Hansi Superintendent of Police Vinod Kumar confirmed that the post claiming responsibility is being examined. "The police are probing the case from all angles, including gang rivalry, personal enmity and extortion. The accused will be arrested soon," he said.

Preliminary investigation has ruled out any domestic dispute as a motive. As per police records, Redhu was facing four criminal cases, including charges related to murder and attempt to murder, registered in 2023 and 2024. These cases are still under investigation.

Deputy Superintendent of Police (Headquarters) Vinod Shankar noted that Redhu had been operating the gym for the past three years. Criminal Investigation Agency (CIA) teams and forensic experts have visited the scene. CCTV footage from

the area, including the viral video of the attack itself, is being analysed to trace the assailants' movements and possible escape route toward Tosham in Bhiwani district.

Investigators say the manner of the attack suggests the involvement of professional criminals who were familiar with the victim's daily routine. The Lawrence Bishnoi gang has been linked to several high-profile targeted killings in recent years, often claiming responsibility through social media posts and audio messages, with many members reportedly operating from abroad.

The crime scene has been sealed, and a massive search operation has been launched. The police are questioning people associated with Redhu to establish the exact motive behind the killing. Further details are awaited as the investigation progresses, police said.

Omar congratulates PM on 12 years in office



MOHIT KANDHARI ■ Jammu

Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah on Thursday congratulated Prime Minister Narendra Modi on completing 12 uninterrupted years in office, describing the milestone as a significant achievement.

Omar, who is currently visiting New Delhi, called on Prime Minister Narendra Modi and discussed a range of issues concerning Jammu and Kashmir, including the early restoration of statehood, economic growth, developmental initiatives, and the promotion of tourism in the Union Territory.

The meeting took place close on the heels of an INDIA bloc meeting at the Constitution Club of India in New Delhi on June 8. During the meeting, Omar is learnt to have sought the alliance's support for the restoration of J&K statehood and invited opposition leaders to a planned demonstration in the capital.

In Srinagar, National Conference president Farooq Abdullah on Thursday said his party will not invite any political party from Jammu and Kashmir to join its protest in Delhi for restoration of statehood. "Whoever wants to join the protest can do so. We

are not going to anyone with a (begging) bowl," Abdullah told reporters. The National Conference had earlier announced its decision to stage a protest in New Delhi demanding restoration of statehood to Jammu and Kashmir on the first day of the monsoon session of Parliament.

Following the meeting with the Prime Minister, Omar said he discussed several matters of importance to Jammu and Kashmir with the Prime Minister, including the early return of statehood, the condition of the economy, the pace of development and measures to further boost tourism in the region.

In a post on X, the Office of the Chief Minister posted, "The Chief Minister called on the Prime Minister Narendra Modi in New Delhi today and discussed key issues concerning Jammu & Kashmir, including the early restoration of statehood, state of the economy and the pace of development. The Chief Minister also highlighted the need for continued support from the Government of India to accelerate economic growth, strengthen connectivity, generate employment, expand infrastructure and enhance public welfare across Jammu & Kashmir".

Mayapuri factory fire triggers building collapse, latest in series of blazes across Delhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

A portion of a factory building collapsed after a major fire broke out at an industrial unit in west Delhi's Mayapuri area on Thursday, prompting a massive firefighting operation involving 18 fire tenders, officials said.

According to the Delhi Fire Service (DFS), a distress call was received regarding the blaze at a factory in Phase I of the Mayapuri Industrial Area in the morning. The fire rapidly spread through a factory operating on the first and second floors of the building, which specialised in steel cutting and packing materials.

Officials said the structure, spread across nearly 500 square

yards, consists of a basement, ground floor and two upper floors. As the fire intensified, additional fire tenders rushed to the spot to contain the flames. During firefighting operations, portions of the first and second floors collapsed due to structural damage from the blaze, raising concerns about the building's stability.

"The building remains in a dangerous condition due to the damage caused by the fire and the subsequent collapse," a DFS official said.

The fire was brought under control by around 2.20 pm. Officials added that no casualties or injuries had been reported by the time this report was filed.

The incident is the latest in a



Representative image

PTI

series of recent fire-related emergencies reported in the capital, highlighting concerns over fire safety standards in industrial and commercial establishments.

On June 6, a massive fire broke

out at a plastic factory in Delhi's Narela Industrial Area, triggering a large-scale response from fire officials. No casualties were reported in that incident either.

The city has also witnessed several deadly fires in recent weeks, including the blaze at a Malviya Nagar hotel that claimed 22 lives and renewed scrutiny of fire safety compliance and emergency preparedness across the capital.

Authorities are yet to ascertain the cause of the Mayapuri fire. An investigation has been initiated to determine whether any safety violations contributed to the incident. Fire officials are also assessing the damaged building's structural condition before allowing any further access to the premises.

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Centre, States must work together, says PM Modi

The annual NITI Aayog meeting, chaired by the PM, has in recent years been marked by boycotts and absences from several chief ministers, particularly those heading Opposition-ruled states. This year, however, broke that trend. Chief Ministers from all 28 states attended the forum on Thursday, making it one of the most widely attended editions of the council in recent past. Among those present were Tamil Nadu CM Joseph Vijay, Karnataka CM DK Shivakumar, Kerala CM VD Satheesan, Jammu and Kashmir CM Omar Abdullah, Jharkhand CM Hemant Soren. They also met the PM later in the day separately. Additionally, the Lieutenant Governors of Union Territories and several Union ministers attended the meeting.

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay, in his maiden address at the NITI Aayog meeting on Thursday, requested the Centre to release the ₹3,284 crore Samagra Shiksha funds to the state without insisting on any riders.

The PM asked every State to further strengthen the nation's resolve towards self-reliance and highlighted the importance of adopting and implementing global best practices, particularly in the renewable energy sector.

Highlighting the importance of good governance, transparency, and infrastructure for attracting investment, PM Modi urged States to focus on branding, ease of doing business, and emerging opportunities in sectors such as data centres and artificial intelligence. The PM also drew attention to concerns arising from El Niño conditions and appealed to States to promote water conservation and encourage natural and organic farming practices.

Underscoring the importance of cooperative federalism, the Prime Minister stated that the Centre and the States must work together to achieve the goal of a Viksit Bharat. He stressed that the vision of Viksit Bharat should become the collective resolve of every State, district, block and village.

Prime Minister urged States to focus on One District One Product (ODOP) initiatives and develop export-oriented strategies around it. He also identified defence manufacturing as an emerging sector where India is establishing a distinct identity and encouraged States to formulate policies to leverage the opportunities arising from its growth.

Last year, four opposition chief ministers, such as West Bengal's Mamata Banerjee, Kerala's Pinarayi Vijayan, Karnataka's Siddaramaiah and Bihar's Nitish Kumar, skipped the 10th Governing Council meeting.

In 2024, as many as 10 chief ministers were absent from the meeting, with several opposition leaders boycotting the event, while others skipped it due to prior commitments and instead sent representatives on their behalf. A similar trend was witnessed in 2023, when nine chief ministers stayed away. The years before that also followed a comparable pattern.

Kharge, Chugh win RS seats unopposed

According to the Election Commission's designated Returning Officers (RO), three Congress candidates, including Kharge, and one BJP nominee were declared elected "unanimously" to the Rajya Sabha from Karnataka.

Alongside Kharge, the other newly elected members are AICC Secretary Mansoor Ali Khan, Congress's Media and Publicity Department chairperson Pawan Khera, and BJP's M Nagaraja.

In Andhra Pradesh, all four NDA candidates — Bashyam Ramakrishna, Chintakayala Vijay and Sana Satish Babu from TDP and Lingamaneni Ramesh of Jana Sena were elected unopposed for the RS. Though Babu retired from the Rajya Sabha recently, he secured another term in the latest biennial election. Other members who retired include A Ayodhya Rami Reddy, Parimal Nathwani, P Subhash Chandra Bose, all from YSRCP.

Similarly in BJP ruled state of Gujarat all four candidates — Rajubhai Shukla, Mansinh Parmar, Mukeshbhai Rathwa and Jitendra Kanjariya were elected unopposed to the Rajya Sabha. Opposition Congress did not field its candidate hence no other contestant was in the poll fray.

The elections to the Rajya Sabha were necessitated as the six-year term of four sitting MPs — Rambhai Mokariya, Narhari Amin, and Ramlaben Bara (all from BJP), and Shaktisinh Gohil (Congress) — is to end on June 21.

BJP candidate Debashish Samantaray was elected unopposed to the Upper House from Odisha. Samantaray, who joined BJP recently had quit the BJD and resigned as its MP from the Rajya Sabha. Further, even as Congress candidate Meenakshi Natarajan has moved the Supreme Court against the rejection of her nomination, the Madhya Pradesh returning officer declared the three BJP candidates elected unopposed in the biennial elections in the State. Tarun Chugh, Rajneesh Agarwal and Mahesh Kewat were declared elected.

Congress had nominated Natarajan but her nomination was rejected on the ground that she concealed information about a court complaint filed. BJP has 164 MLAs in the 230-member Madhya Pradesh Assembly while the Congress has 62 MLAs eligible to vote. With each Rajya Sabha candidate requiring 58 votes to win, the BJP was assured of winning two seats comfortably, while the Congress had enough votes to win a single seat. BJP fielded a third candidate, whose victory would have depended on cross-voting or abstention by opposition members had polling taken place.

From Rajasthan three candidates, two from ruling BJP, Satish Poonia and Alka Gurjar, and one from Congress Neeraj Dangi were elected unopposed to the Upper House.

While Tai Tagak was declared elected unopposed to the lone Rajya Sabha seat from Arunachal Pradesh, National People's Party (NPP) national vice president James K Sangma was elected unopposed to the lone RS seat from Meghalaya. James K Sangma, the brother of Chief Minister Conrad Sangma, was declared elected after no other candidate remained in the fray.

Bangladesh rallies against India's...

Nasiruddin Patwary Chief Coordinator of Bangladesh based National Citizen Party for a stronger BGB and asked border communities to form a human shield, "So that terrorists, smugglers or criminals cannot enter Bangladesh." These comments come as political activity increases in Bangladesh after the 2024 political transition and elections. Jamaat-e-Islami, which India has long viewed with concern because of its history and ideology,

has become more popular in several border districts.

The timing is significant because the 57th Director General-level Border Coordination Conference between India's Border Security Force (BSF) and Border Guard Bangladesh (BGB) is ending in New Delhi this week, from June 8 to 11.

The current BSF-BGB conference in the capital is the highest regular forum for resolving these issues, push-backs, alleged killings, fencing gaps and trans-border crime. Both sides have mechanisms to manage differences, and India has invested heavily in smart fencing, surveillance, and rapid-response capabilities along the frontier.

"India respects Bangladesh's sovereignty and seeks a friendly, stable neighbour. It will, however, exercise its sovereign right to control its borders and deport illegal entrants", a senior official involved in the process said.

From New Delhi's standpoint, the narrative of 'push-ins' differs from India's view of a legitimate exercise of sovereign authority.

India has long grappled with large-scale illegal immigration from Bangladesh, and this porous 4,096-km border has fuelled economic migration and security concerns, including infiltration linked to crime syndicates, radical elements and demographic pressures in states like Assam, West Bengal and Tripura.

Successive Indian Governments have pursued a 'detect, delete, deport' approach.

India maintains that these are not arbitrary expulsions but actions against foreign nationals who are present illegally, often following due verification. In that framework, Indian officials have repeatedly stated that a bilateral mechanism exists for nationality verification. Cases are referred to Bangladesh for confirmation before formal deportation.

India has consistently advocated zero tolerance for violence while emphasising that BSF personnel operate under strict rules of engagement in a challenging environment of smuggling, cattle theft and human trafficking.

India has faced similar provocations in the past and views them as escalatory rather than constructive. Border management is a state responsibility, not a matter for political mobilisation that blurs lines between civilians and security forces. India expects Bangladesh to strengthen its own border controls and address the root drivers of outward migration, primarily economic. Stable bilateral relations benefit both nations through trade, connectivity and people-to-people ties. However, these cannot come at the cost of India's internal security and demographic integrity.

Keep him or us: Kalyan challenges Mamata

However, he would continue to handle cases for the party itself. He said he would ask Mamata to either keep Abhishek and let party veterans go, or keep them and remove Abhishek.

"His arrogant attitude has destroyed the party. Every day, he thinks he is the 'king,'" Kalyan said. He further alleged that Abhishek's "arrogant attitude" and "fluctuating mindset" had damaged the party and made it difficult for seniors to work effectively.

The developments underscore deepening factional tensions in the TMC as it grapples

with electoral setbacks, legal challenges, and a wave of resignations and defections. Mamata Banerjee has yet to respond publicly to the ultimatum. "One must respect seniors. How can he humiliate me?" Kalyan Banerjee said. "Abhishek has many advisors; I would not represent him in any court cases in future."

Abhishek Banerjee is facing an investigation in the signature forgery case, and the Calcutta High Court recently granted him interim protection from arrest and directed him to appear before the CID. Kalyan Banerjee had been involved in the related proceedings until the reported change of counsel.

Mamata Banerjee is battling the exodus of TMC MLAs and MPs after her party's heavy defeat in the May 2026 West Bengal Assembly elections. On Thursday, the internal crisis in TMC widened further with Rajya Sabha MP Prakash Chik Baraik resigning from the Upper House and the party.

A tribal leader from West Bengal, Baraik, was serving as a member of the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Consumer Affairs, Food and Public Distribution and the Consultative Committee on Tribal Affairs. His resignation adds to a series of exits from the Trinamool Congress.

Rebel voices within the party have claimed significant support among MLAs and MPs, with reports of attempts to form a separate group in Parliament and possible realignments. The coming days will reveal whether Mamata Banerjee addresses the rift or if more senior leaders voice similar discontent.

SC calls homemakers nation builders, fixes...

Quoting economist Sir Cecil Pigou, the top court said, "the services rendered by women enter into the dividend when they are rendered in exchange for wages, whether in the factory or in the home, but do not enter into it when they are rendered by mothers and wives gratuitously to their own families. Thus, if a man marries his housekeeper or his cook, the national dividend is diminished."

"Apart from the fact that contribution of women to the society extends far beyond biological reproduction, they are also largely responsible for the preparation of human capital on which the dreams of being the world's largest economy, among other things, rest. "The 'homemakers', to put it directly, actually are the 'nation builders' and they ought to be recognised as such," the bench said.

Voicing concern over the delay in cases of motor accident compensation claims, the top court said such matters should be decided within one year. It asked the chief justices of all the high courts to monitor the progress of cases related to the Motor Vehicles Act.

"The Chief Justices of the High Courts are requested to issue necessary directions to have matters that have remained pending for the longest amount of time, listed according to the date of institution of the appeal, before the appropriate benches.

"The average taken for such purposes is any case that has remained pending for more than four years. For clarity, it may be stated that if matter 'a' has been pending for eight and a half years and 'b' has been pending for four years, 'a' will be listed first," the bench said.

The top court's judgement came on an appeal relating to a motor accident claim in

Punjab where a woman named died in a road accident on November 25, 2001.

The husband and three children of the deceased approached the Motor Accident Claims Tribunal seeking compensation, which granted them ₹2.42 lakh.

Being aggrieved, the claimants approached the Punjab and Haryana High Court seeking enhancement of the amount.

The high court enhanced the compensation to ₹8.43 lakh along with 7.5 per cent interest.

Still dissatisfied, the claimants approached the top court.

US Strikes Iran Again

The exchanges have triggered alarm in global energy markets, pushing oil prices higher due to concerns over potential disruptions in the vital shipping lane.

Iran's Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps said it launched attacks on US facilities in Bahrain, Kuwait, and Jordan. Iranian media reported that ballistic missiles struck Jordan's Muwaffaq Salti Air Base, claiming damage to infrastructure. Neither Jordan nor the US has verified these reports, though both countries activated air defences and intercepted incoming projectiles.

Kuwait briefly halted air traffic after detecting hostile aerial activity, while Bahrain reported interceptions of drones, with debris falling in residential zones and causing minor injuries. The US Embassy in Jordan issued an emergency alert, urging American citizens to seek shelter amid missile and drone threats.

In a related development, local media in Lebanon reported an Israeli strike near Baalbek in the Bekaa Valley, as tensions with Hezbollah persist. With hundreds of Indian seafarers deployed across the Gulf at any time, New Delhi is pressing for stronger protection for merchant navy personnel while calling for de-escalation to prevent further loss of civilian lives.

AFSPA to be rolled back: Amit Shah

"This will open new avenues for mineral exploration in the Northeast. The area not only has oil and gas but huge mineral deposits, which could not be explored due to law and order issues," Shah said. With just one MoU, the extraction capacity of 1,000-1,500 barrels per day can be increased by 10 times, he said.

"In one field alone, there are possibilities of recovery of more than ₹15,000 crore. If we extract the oil deposits spread across Nagaland, we would be able to reduce dependence on foreign countries for our oil needs," he said. Shah also said that since Narendra Modi took charge, he kept his focus on the Northeast and became the prime minister with the highest number of visits to the region.

Since 2019, 12 accords have been signed between various groups and state Governments, which resulted in a significant drop of around 80 per cent in incidents of violence in the region, Shah said.

"The development of both Assam and Nagaland remained hampered for a long time because a consensus could not be reached for an MoU. The avenue that opened today will open doors for development for both states. It is the best example of cooperative federalism," he said.

No Viksit Bharat without States becoming developed: PM Modi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Thursday emphasised that India cannot become Viksit Bharat without all states becoming developed, and stressed the importance of ease of doing business to attract investments.

The Prime Minister made these remarks at the Niti Aayog's 11th Governing Council meeting held at the Rashtrapati Bhawan.

Briefing the media about the day-long meeting, Niti Aayog Vice-Chairperson Ashok Kumar Lahiri also informed that chief ministers of all 28 states participated and the discussions focused on the 'Inclusive Human Development Framework'.

The Prime Minister, as well as the chief ministers, spoke



FARMERS ARE PILLARS OF FOOD SECURITY: PM

New Delhi: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Thursday emphasised that farmers are the pillars of the country's food security and the government is leaving no stone unturned to make their lives easier. Modi also said initiatives like PM-Kisan Samman Nidhi and Fasal Bima Yojana are securing farmers' income and empowering agriculture, while the PM-KUSUM scheme provides accessible solar energy, thereby reducing farming expenditures. "Our farmer brothers and sisters are the pillars of the country's food security, nutrition, and prosperity, and the government is leaving no stone unturned to make their lives easier," he was quoted as saying in a release issued by the Prime Minister's Office.

on various aspects related to energy security, including rooftop solar energy.

Modi, who is the Chairperson of the Council, also asked the states to estimate GDP at the district level to ascertain development and growth at the micro level, a Niti Aayog member informed.

Responding to a question, Lahiri said the Prime Minister,

chief ministers and the other members of the Governing Council are aware that India needs planned urbanisation. He said no chief minister asked for any specific assistance to deal with the situation created due to the West Asia crisis.

To another query, Lahiri categorically stated that no discussions on paper leaks took place.

EAC-PM proposes targeted delimitation model

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A working paper from the Economic Advisory Council to the Prime Minister (EAC-PM) has proposed a "targeted delimitation" model, splitting 170 existing Lok Sabha constituencies into smaller units to increase the lower house's strength to 824 from the current 543 to address oversized constituencies and improve electoral participation.

The paper, titled "Constituency Size, Composition and the Case for Delimitation in India's Lok Sabha (2009-2024)", also recommends that a delimitation exercise be paired with women-specific measures, such as women-only polling booths and evening polling hours. It further



argues that a future delimitation exercise should not rely only on uniform seat division but identify constituencies where restructuring would have the greatest impact on representation and voter access.

"A targeted plan that splits 170 of the 543 constituencies into 824 in total (59 two-way splits and 111 three-way splits) is predicted to raise national voter turnout by between 0.3 and 2.3 percentage points at the next

general election, corresponding to 9 to 23 million additional voters," says the paper authored by EAC-PM member Dr Shamika Ravi and Mudit Kapoor of the Economics and Planning Unit at the Indian Statistical Institute (Delhi Centre).

It has been uploaded on the EAC-PM website at a time when the government has indicated that it plans to reintroduce three bills in Parliament to carry out nationwide delimitation,

increase the Lok Sabha's sanctioned seat strength from 550 to 850, and reserve one-third of the seats for women in the Lok Sabha and state legislatures.

The bills, including one that proposed a constitutional amendment, were defeated in the Lok Sabha during a special sitting of Parliament in April after the government failed to secure the required two-thirds majority due to resistance from a united opposition.

The EAC-PM paper recommends splitting 59 constituencies into two parts and 111 constituencies into three parts, creating 824 constituencies.

Under the proposed model, Kerala and Tamil Nadu alone account for 22 of the 59 proposed two-way splits.

Congress to launch campaign to corner Govt on price rise, paper leaks

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Congress on Thursday announced that it will launch a nationwide campaign to corner the government on rising prices, unemployment, examination paper leaks and "electoral manipulation".

The decision was taken at a meeting of the party general secretaries, state in-charges and Pradesh Congress Committee presidents held at the party headquarters under the chairmanship of Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge.

Besides Kharge, former party chief Rahul Gandhi, Congress general secretaries Priyanka Gandhi Vadra, K C Venugopal and Jairam Ramesh, Bhupesh Baghel, in-charges, PCC chiefs, among others, participated in the meeting.

Speaking to reporters, Congress general secretary in-charge communications Jairam Ramesh said the nationwide campaign will be launched by the end of June.

"We have learned that a trade deal agreement will be reached on June 22. Farmers in Madhya Pradesh,



Jairam Ramesh

Bihar, Maharashtra, Rajasthan, Jammu and Kashmir, and Himachal Pradesh will be significantly affected. So, the first issue concerns farmers. The second issue is related to NEET and CBSE," he said.

A law against paper leaks was enacted two years ago, but it has had no impact, Ramesh said.

He said Gandhi made the point during the meeting that all these irregularities stem from centralisation.

"The third issue is related to democracy. There is a 'double engine' at work to dismantle democracy -- one engine is vote chori, and the other is seat chori," Ramesh said, adding that this "double engine" is endangering

democracy and the Constitution.

Democracy is at risk because constitutional provisions are under threat, he alleged.

After the meeting, Kharge said the country was faced with serious challenges such as inflation, unemployment, exam scams and social inequality.

"Paper leaks in NEET and various recruitment exams, along with controversies related to the education system, have shaken the trust of millions of youth and their families," he said, adding that Gandhi has personally met with affected students and the youth and firmly presented their voice before the nation.

Congress only party not breaking down ideologically: Rahul



Congress President Mallikarjun Kharge, left, and party leader Rahul Gandhi during a meeting at AICC headquarters, Indira Bhawan, in New Delhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Congress is the only party which is not breaking down ideologically and therefore it is best suited to take on the RSS-BJP, Rahul Gandhi said at an internal party meeting on Thursday amid the TMC political crisis.

Speaking at the meeting of the Congress top brass with general secretaries, in-charges and state unit chiefs here, Gandhi asserted that the party will strengthen further in the next couple of years due to its ideological steadfastness, sources said.

Gandhi noted that the country's economy is in a very "fragile state" and asserted that this was due to the government's policies and not merely due to international factors, he said. The Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha said that pressure should be exerted so that the prime minister must speak on this situation, the sources said.

During the meeting, Gandhi also alleged that constitutional provisions in tribal areas in states and Union territories like Madhya Pradesh, Odisha,

Jharkhand, Chhattisgarh and the Andaman and Nicobar islands are being deliberately violated to benefit industrialists favoured by the prime minister.

"If one party is not breaking down ideologically, it is the Congress. If there is one party that can fight the RSS-BJP, it is the Congress," Gandhi was quoted as saying by the sources.

Gandhi's remarks come amid the crisis TMC is facing following its defeat in the West Bengal assembly polls and a rebellion that has significantly weakened its organisational and legislative strength.

Last week, more than two-thirds of the TMC's MLAs — 58 out of 80 — broke away from the official legislature party and secured recognition as the principal opposition bloc in the West Bengal assembly under expelled legislator Ritabrata Banerjee. The rebel camp has since claimed that its strength has risen further.

The crisis later spread to Parliament, with rebel MPs led by Kakoli Ghosh Dastidar claiming the support of more than 20 Lok Sabha members.

Urban agenda takes centre stage as BRICS Forum opens in Delhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

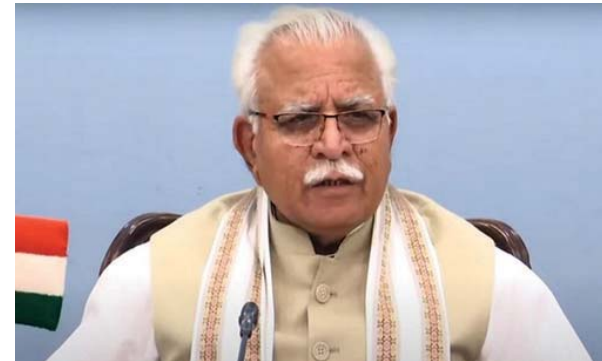
A two-day BRICS Urbanisation Forum commenced here on Thursday, with Union Housing and Urban Affairs Minister Manohar Lal describing it as a key platform to place urban development more prominently within the global development discourse.

Hosted by the Union Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs (MoHUA) under India's BRICS Chairship, the

forum is being attended by ministers, senior government officials and urban practitioners from Brazil, Russia, Indonesia, India, China, South Africa, Egypt, Ethiopia, Iran and the United Arab Emirates.

The forum focuses on the theme — 'Cities for People: BRICS Cooperation for Inclusive and Resilient Urban Futures'.

Addressing the inaugural session, Manohar Lal said the platform offers an opportunity to bring the urban agenda more firmly



into global development discussions. According to the govern-

ment, India is hosting the BRICS Urbanisation Forum for the fourth time, following

the editions held in New Delhi in 2013, Visakhapatnam in 2016 and virtually in 2021.

The minister said, "Under India's BRICS Chairship, this Forum is an opportunity to bring the urban agenda more firmly into the global development conversation."

He highlighted the anchors of India's development story as inclusive urban development, climate and disaster-resilient infrastructure, strengthening institutions, and digital innovation.

Indian Navy disposes of unexploded missile warhead from oil tanker

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Indian Navy has recovered and safely disposed of a missile warhead from a merchant tanker, it said here on Thursday, adding there were no Indians onboard the Marshall Islands-flagged tanker MT Olympic Life.

Giving details, the Navy said the ship was on passage from Fujairah, UAE, to Kochi and reported an explosion in its hull while off the coast of Oman on May 26. The vessel reported the presence of an unexploded ordnance as it



Indian Navy's Explosive Ordnance Disposal team successfully extracted an unexploded missile warhead lodged inside a fuel tank of Marshall Islands-flagged crude oil tanker MT Olympic Life, which was on passage from Fujairah, UAE, to Kochi, while off the coast of Oman on 26th May, in New Delhi

continued its transit towards Kochi.

On receipt of information through the Information Fusion Centre - Indian Ocean Region (IFC-IOR), the Indian Navy initiated a coordinated response. Kochi-based Southern Naval Command deployed a specialist Explosive Ordnance Disposal (EOD) team for a detailed assessment. The team confirmed that a projectile had penetrated the vessel's hull, traversed multiple structural compartments and was lodged inside a fuel tank. In view of the risks associ-

ated with the presence of an unexploded missile warhead inside a fuel storage compartment, the EOD team adopted a deliberate and phased approach to ensure the safety of the ship, its crew and surrounding port infrastructure.

After completion of prescribed safety procedures, the EOD team employed advanced diagnostic methods to identify and isolate the detonation mechanism before carrying out the safe extraction of the warhead along with the associated debris.

Punjab seeks special category status, financial package for border areas from Union Govt

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Singh Mann on Thursday strongly raised the state's long-pending concerns before the NITI Aayog Governing Council, seeking special category status and a financial package for the revitalisation of border areas.

The Chief Minister demanded that Punjab should be accorded 'special category status' with 90:10 funding under all centrally sponsored schemes along the lines of hill states, North Eastern states and Jammu & Kashmir.



Addressing the meeting, CM Mann highlighted the extraordinary security, economic and social challenges

faced by Punjab as a frontline border state and asserted that the state's aspirations are fully aligned with the

national goal of Viksit Bharat 2047.

Emphasising the unique challenges faced by Punjab, Mann said, "Punjab is a frontline state sharing a 553-kilometre border with Pakistan. The state faces a deep and multidimensional crisis that includes persistent cross-border terrorism and drone-based smuggling of heroin and weapons. This has resulted in a drug addiction epidemic among youth, organised crime and daily hardship for farmers cultivating land between the security fence and the international border under the BSF escort."

Temporary migration for work no ground to deny PM Awas Yojana-Gramin benefits: Govt to CIC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Eligible migrant labourers cannot be denied pucca houses under the Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana-Gramin (PMAY-G) merely because they are temporarily residing outside their native village for employment, the Ministry of Rural Development has informed the Central Information Commission (CIC).

The clarification came during the hearing of an RTI appeal in which an applicant had sought information on whether rural families migrating temporarily for work could be deprived of

benefits under PMAY-G and other rural welfare schemes.

According to a recent CIC order, the ministry submitted that "there is no specific order/circular/rule issued by the Ministry of Rural Development to the effect that a family shall be denied benefits under PMAY-G solely on the grounds that they are temporarily residing outside their native place for employment or labour purposes".

The ministry further informed the CIC that eligibility under PMAY-G is determined in accordance with the framework and guidelines issued by the Centre, while the scheme is implemented by state governments.

The commission specifically asked the ministry whether any policy or rule exists that denies PMAY-G benefits to eligible beneficiaries because they are staying outside their native place.

In response, the ministry stated that "no such rule/policy exists".

The ministry also explained that beneficiaries under PMAY-G are identified on the basis of housing deprivation parameters under the Socio-Economic and Caste Census (SECC) 2011, followed by verification through Gram Sabhas and the prescribed appeal process.

Financial assistance is provided to eligible rural house-

holds that are homeless or living in kutcha houses, subject to the scheme guidelines, it added.

Information Commissioner Khushwant Singh Sethi observed that the respondents had explained the factual position regarding the issues raised in the RTI application.

The commission directed the Ministry of Rural Development and the Department of Drinking Water and Sanitation to provide a revised point-wise reply to the appellant, incorporating available factual information, specific website links and copies of relevant policies and rules.

States Focus



TWO EMPTY TRAIN RAKES FACE EACH OTHER IN BHUBANESWAR

Two empty train rakes came face-to-face on the same track near the Jharpada bridge area in Bhubaneswar on Thursday, railway officials said. However, railways said that there was no casualty, or disruption to train services. “Timely intervention reportedly prevented an accident. No injuries reported,” a railway Statement said. Railway officials and technical staff promptly attended the site and took necessary measures to secure the rolling stock and assess the situation, an official Statement issued by the East Coast Railways said. Train operations on the main line and passenger services remain unaffected, it said. The ECoR said that one empty train rake was travelling from Bhubaneswar to Mancheswar coach maintenance depot, the other was heading towards Bhubaneswar from Mancheswar coach maintenance depot on the same route. The incident took place at Bhubaneswar during a shunting operation involving an empty train rake that was being moved for scheduled maintenance activities. (PTI)



T-55 USED IN INDO-PAK WARS INSTALLED AT HAZARE'S VILLAGE

A decommissioned Indian Army T-55 tank that was in action in the 1965 and 1971 India-Pakistan wars was installed at veteran activist Anna Hazare's village Ralegan Siddhi in Maharashtra's Ahilyanagar district on Thursday. Hazare thanked the Government for allotting the tank and said it would inspire villagers and visitors alike. “The tank provided by the Ministry of Defence will inspire people in the village as well as the visitors who come to see Ralegan Siddhi. It displayed exemplary valour on the battlefield during the 1965 and 1971 India-Pakistan wars,” said Hazare, who had served in the Indian Army. (PTI)

Owaisi demands ECI accept PAN Card, driving licence for SIR



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Hyderabad

AIMIM president Asaduddin Owaisi on Thursday demanded that the ECI accept PAN cards, driving licences, and PDS ration cards as identity proofs for voter verification during the SIR. Speaking to reporters after a meeting of Muslim organisations here, he said that of the 12 identity proofs approved by the Election Commission, three are not available in Telangana. The three documents are the Permanent Residence Certificate, the NRC, and the Family Register (prepared by State or local authorities). “The EC itself has said the list of 12 documents is not exhaustive. It is therefore necessary that they accept the PAN card, driving licence, and food security card issued by the State Government,” he said. He urged Chief Minister A Revanth Reddy to make efforts to include the driving licence, PDS ration card, and other documents issued by the State Government in the list of valid proofs for establishing voter identity. Since three documents on the approved list are unavailable in Telangana, he said, the CM and the State Government's chief secretary should formally inform the EC about the documents issued by the State Government that could serve as alternatives. He clarified that Permanent Residence Certificates and Family Registers are not issued in Telangana, and that the National Register of Citizens (NRC) exercise has not been conducted in the State.

Ashok Gehlot affectionate towards me: Sachin Pilot

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Jaipur

Senior Congress leader Sachin Pilot on Thursday sought to downplay former Rajasthan chief minister Ashok Gehlot's recent criticism of him, saying Gehlot has always shown him affection. He added that all Congress leaders and workers should remain united to strengthen the party and to fight the BJP. Responding to questions from reporters on Gehlot's remarks in Dausa, Pilot adopted a measured tone and avoided any direct attack on the veteran Congress leader. “I heard his Statement. What I remember is that he said he has for me the same affection and attachment he has for his son Vaibhav Gehlot. We are all soldiers of the Congress party,” Pilot said. The remarks came days after Gehlot said that the events of September 2022 were not a revolt against the Congress high command but MLAs' Opposition to Pilot's possible elevation as chief minister. On Sunday, Gehlot said MLAs loyal to him were willing to accept any leader chosen by the party high command except Pilot, as they still resent Pilot's 2020



rebellion against the then Congress Government. He also said Pilot should “accept the truth” and acknowledge his mistakes. Pilot pointed out that Congress leaders and workers across the country were working together to spread the message of harmony and to take on the BJP. “Rahul Gandhi has given a message across the country that we must open a 'mohabbat ki dukan'. We all have to collectively fight the BJP's misgovernance. Leaders, workers and office-bearers are carrying forward that struggle together. I am confident that Congress has always remained strong in Rajasthan and has set an example in the country.

VB-G RAM G: Karnataka minister urges Centre for 80:20 wage sharing

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Bengaluru

Karnataka Rural Development Minister Eshwar Khandre on Thursday urged the Centre to increase the Centre-State wage-sharing ratio under the new rural employment guarantee scheme, VB-G RAM G, which has replaced MGNREGA, to at least 80:20. He also Stated that the centre's decision not to provide employment for 60 days in a year under the new scheme is “neither correct nor justifiable.” “Under MGNREGA, which was launched by the UPA Government in 2006, the



Karnataka Rural Development Minister Eshwar Khandre

Mamata struggles to keep her party united

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH ■ New Delhi

Just a month after losing power in West Bengal, Mamata Banerjee's Trinamool Congress (TMC) is quickly breaking apart. Most of the remaining legislators and parliamentarians have left the main group, taken over the party's legislative wing, and left Banerjee struggling to stop more splits. In the 2026 Assembly elections, the BJP won about 208 seats, while TMC got around 80, down from 215 seats in 2021. Mamata Banerjee lost in Bhabanipur to the BJP's Suwendu Adhikari, who is now the Chief Minister. After the loss, the party quickly faced internal problems. Around June 3-4, about 58-60 rebel MLAs, led by expelled leader Ritabrata Banerjee, wrote to the Assembly Speaker saying they were the real TMC legislative party. The Speaker recognised them. They then met the Governor to make their claim. Their numbers protect them from immediate anti-defection action.

The rebels have made serious accusations, including claims of forged signatures on documents submitted to the Speaker, increased control by Mamata's nephew, Abhishek Banerjee, and what they call an “Operation Crown Prince” to consolidate dynastic control. They have also questioned why no action has been taken against legislators close to Abhishek and criticised how the party was managed after the election. The crisis has reached Delhi. Reports say that up to 20 of 28 TMC Lok Sabha MPs have distanced themselves from the official leadership. Some have met with BJP leaders and shown they might support the NDA. Veteran MP Kakoli Ghosh Dastidar is among those who have publicly left. Mamata Banerjee has responded quickly by expelling some members (including Ritabrata Banerjee), rallying loyalists at her Kalighat home, and dissolving several party groups to strengthen her control. Loyalists argue the rebels are opportunists exploiting



the defeat. Supporters of Mamata Banerjee say the rebels are taking advantage of the defeat and may have help from rivals. However, the wide scope of the revolt in both the Assembly and Parliament suggests there are deeper problems that existed before the election loss. TMC was built around one leader's charisma, direct connection with voters, and tight control over patronage and resources. That model delivered spectacular success while in power. Stripped of State authority, the same structure has revealed its fragility. Once the glue of

office and fear dissolves, legislators and MPs begin to calculate their individual survival. The speed of the unravelling is striking. In roughly two weeks of open revolt, the party that ended the Left Front's 34-year rule and held the BJP at bay for over a decade now risks becoming a diminished, fragmented force. Whether the rebels succeed in claiming the party name and symbols, or whether further desertions follow, will determine whether TMC survives as a coherent entity or becomes less relevant.

WILL NOT LEAVE MAMATA: SHATRUGHAN

New Delhi: Shatrughan Sinha on Thursday said he would remain with TMC leader Mamata Banerjee, saying she stood by him during a difficult period in his political career. The TMC MP from Asansol said that although some have left Banerjee for various reasons, he would not leave the party or its leader. “I am issuing a three-line whip to myself. I was with the TMC and Mamata ji, I am with the TMC and Mamata ji, and I will stay with the TMC and Mamata ji. I have no intention of going anywhere,” Sinha said. Political parties typically issue a three-line whip before voting on important issues in Parliament. Sinha made these remarks after his name appeared in a list of alleged rebel TMC MPs circulating online and after he posted on X to congratulate Prime Minister Narendra Modi on completing 12 years in office, prompting

speculation. Sinha was previously a member of the Congress before joining the TMC. Sinha said he would not leave Mamata Banerjee in her difficult times. He added that very few people stood by him when he lost, or rather was made to lose the (Lok Sabha) polls from Patna in 2019, and that Banerjee was one of them. The actor-turned-politician Sinha contested the 2019 Lok Sabha elections on a Congress ticket from Patna Sahib in Bihar. His wife, Poonam Sinha, was the Samajwadi Party candidate from Lucknow in Uttar Pradesh. “We extend our best wishes to our friend and guide of society/nation, Hon'ble PM Narendra Modi, on completing 12 years in office, perhaps the longest tenure ever. Wish you a long, healthy and prosperous life ahead. Jai Hind!” Sinha said in a post on X. (PNS)

Abhishek appears before CID for questioning in signature forgery case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Kolkata

Trinamool Congress (TMC) national general secretary Abhishek Banerjee on Thursday appeared before the West Bengal CID to face questions in the signature forgery case over the party's choice of leader of Opposition in the State Assembly. Banerjee skipped three previous appearance notices before the investigating agency sleuths, citing illness and his filing of a challenge petition before the Calcutta High Court. This was the TMC Diamond Harbour MP's first tryst with a State probe agency following the change of guards at Bengal's power corridors. Earlier, he had been ques-

tioned on multiple occasions by central agencies — ED and CBI — in connection with coal pilferage and school jobs recruitment scams. He reached CID headquarters 'Bhabani Bhaban' at around 5.50 pm after the High Court on Thursday granted him interim protection from any coercive action. The court had directed the TMC MP to appear before the CID at its headquarters by 6 pm on Thursday. Banerjee returned to Kolkata around 4.30 pm from Delhi, where he had spent the past three days holding meetings with INDIA bloc leaders, including Rahul Gandhi. His arrival was marked by chaotic scenes at the airport, where a section of angry people, amid the crowd which had



gathered there, shouted “signature chor” slogans at him. After a nearly 30-minute stopover at his Kalighat residence, Banerjee arrived at Bhabani Bhaban about 10 minutes ahead of the court-stipulated deadline, with the premises wrapped in tight

security cover. The CID, on Tuesday, conducted simultaneous searches at the TMC's central office, at party supremo Mamata Banerjee's Kalighat residence and at Abhishek's Camac Street office in the city in their bid to recover the original

copy of the TMC's meeting resolution book and attendance sheet containing signatures of 70 MLAs present at the May 6 meeting but returned empty-handed. Based on the resolution, the MP had allegedly named Sobhabdeb Chattopadhyay as the assembly's Leader of Opposition, Asima Patra and Nayna Bandopadhyay as deputy LoPs and Firhad Hakim as the chief whip. CID officers had said that Abhishek had sent a written communication to the Speaker on May 20, where he enclosed a copy of the meeting resolution book and the attendance sheet, reiterating the party's endorsement for the assembly posts. Two expelled TMC legislators - Ritabrata Banerjee and

Sandipan Saha - had lodged a complaint before Speaker Rathindra Bose that “no resolution was adopted about the selection of LoP” in the party's May 6 meeting and that the duo had signed the meeting resolution book on a later date, on May 19. The MLAs alleged that the May 6 resolution was “manufactured and fabricated” and Stated that as many as 14 of the 70 signatures were in “block letters”. The CID had taken over the probe from Kolkata Police on May 28, a day after the Hare Street police station registered a case based on a complaint from the principal secretary of the State assembly with charges of cheating, forgery and criminal conspiracy.

Govt committed to promote Assam's rich culture: Himanta

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Guwahati

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Thursday said his Government was committed to preserving and promoting the rich cultural traditions of the State. Congratulating the recipients of the Sangeet Natak Akademi Awards and Ustad Bismillah Khan Yuva Puraskar from the State, Sarma said Sattriya, folk traditions, theatre, music, and cultural roots define the people of Assam.



“Heartiest congratulations to Assam's artistes honoured with the Sangeet Natak Akademi Awards and Ustad Bismillah Khan Yuva Puraskar,” the CM said in a post on X. “As we accelerate Assam's

development journey, we remain equally committed to preserving and promoting our rich virasat of Sattriya, folk traditions, theatre and music, for our cultural roots define who we are,” Sarma said. The Sangeet Natak Akademi awards and Ustad Bismillah Khan Yuva Puraskar for the years 2024 and 2025 were announced on Wednesday. The recipients of Sangeet Natak Akademi awards for the year 2024 are Prema Oja Borbayan for Sattriya dance and Bipul Chandra Das for

Kathak dance. The awardees for 2025 are Chetna Das for acting, Mallika Kandali for Sattriya dance and Bhaskar Jyoti Oja for Sattriya music. The winners of the Ustad Bismillah Khan Yuva Puraskar for 2024 are Minakshi Das for Sattriya dance, Dilip Hira for folk music and Bidyut Kumar Nath for theatre direction. The awardees for 2025 are Niranjan Saikia Borbayan for Sattriya dance, Debajit Saikia for Khol percussion and Hirak Jyoti Sarma for Takari geet (folk music).

Gogoi urges impartial probe into Naga killings

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Guwahati

Deputy Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha Gaurav Gogoi on Thursday urged for a swift, impartial and transparent investigation into the killing of six Naga civilians in Manipur and said those responsible must be identified and brought to justice without delay. Manipur continues to endure the effects of prolonged conflict, with peace and normalcy still remaining elusive more than three years later, Gogoi said in a post on X. “The brutal killing of six Naga civilians in Manipur is a deeply distressing tragedy. My heartfelt condolences to the families of the victims as they cope with this immense



loss”, Gogoi, also the Assam State Congress president, said. “Innocent lives continue to be lost, while communities across the State remain burdened by fear and uncertainty,” he said. This tragic incident underscores the

urgent need for lasting peace and accountability, he added. “There must be a swift, impartial and transparent investigation into this heinous crime, and those responsible must be identified and brought to justice without delay.” Gogoi asserted. The Manipur Police on Wednesday said they found the mortal remains of six people, suspected to be missing Naga men, who had been held hostage by armed groups in Kangpokpi district. The recovery took place a day after 14 Kuki individuals who were abducted by armed groups in Manipur's Senapati district nearly a month ago were released.

ED raids former YSRCP minister, others in liquor transport scam case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Hyderabad

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) on Thursday raided multiple premises, including that of former YSRCP minister Karumuri Nageswara Rao, in a money laundering case linked to an alleged ₹195 crore liquor transport scam in Andhra Pradesh, officials said. They said a total of five premises of persons allegedly involved in the case were searched. This included the premises of former civil supplies minister K Nageswara Rao and his son. The searches were conducted under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act. The investigation is related to the Andhra Pradesh State Beverages Corporation Ltd. ED officials claimed that the accused persons caused wrongful loss to the tune of ₹195.33 crore to the Government exchequer.



Pawan, Nishant among 9 elected to Bihar Legislative Council

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Patna

Bhojpuri superstar Pawan Singh, Bihar Health minister Nishant Kumar and BJP national media co-in-charge Sanjay Mayukh were among nine candidates who on Thursday were declared elected unopposed to the State Legislative Council.

Altogether eight candidates of the ruling NDA and one of the Opposition RJD had filed their nomination papers for nine seats of the Upper House, for which biennial elections were recently announced.

They all were handed over respective certificates of election after the time was up for withdrawal of nomination papers, said an official of the Vidhan Sabha secretariat.



Pawan Singh



Nishant Kumar

Besides, said the official, JD(U) candidate Lalan Saraf was declared elected, unopposed, to a seat where a by-election was announced as it fell vacant upon the resignation of party supremo and former Bihar Chief Minister Nitish Kumar, who is now a Rajya Sabha MP.

The BJP, which held two of

the nine seats to which biennial polls were held, has now bagged four seats with the election of Singh, Mayukh, Anil Thakur and Sheela Pandit. While Singh, who had quit the party in 2024, only to return a year later, and Mayukh belong to the upper castes, the BJP's traditional support base, Thakur and

Pandit, both grassroots-level workers, come from extremely backward classes.

The JD(U) held four of these seats but contested only three in the biennial polls, and besides Nishant, who joined the party in March, two months before getting inducted into the cabinet, the remaining two MLC elects are Bharti Mehta and Shivrani Devi Prajapati.

Mehta is an EBC and one of the party's spokespersons, while Prajapati, an OBC, is a former state general secretary of the JD(U).

Yet another NDA candidate to get elected was Ashraf Ansari of the Lok Janshakti Party (Ram Vilas) headed by Union minister Chirag Paswan, who has rewarded a trusted aide of his late father Ram Vilas Paswan besides

reaching out to the minorities. Ashraf becomes the first person to be elected to the legislative council from LJP, which came into being five years ago, following a split in the LJP founded by the late Paswan. Besides, RJD MLC Sunil Kumar Singh got elected for a third consecutive term, triggering a bit of heartburn in the opposition party headed by his mentor Lalu Prasad.

Former MLA Shiv Chandra Ram, who has been in political wilderness for quite a while, tearfully announced his resignation from the party upon being denied a legislative council ticket. However, his resignation has been turned down.

Except Pawan Singh, whose younger brother visited the Vidhan Sabha sec-

retariat as his representative, all candidates turned up to receive their certificates in person.

Barring Sunil Singh and Sanjay Mayukh, both of whom shall enjoy a third consecutive term, all candidates make their Vidhan Parishad debut.

The current round of legislative council elections led to a bit of rumbling in the ruling NDA as minister Deepak Prakash, son of Rashtriya Lok Morcha president Upendra Kushwaha, was not considered for a ticket. Prakash is not a member of either House of the legislature, and unless he gets elected within six months of his induction in the cabinet last month, the 37-year-old may have to give up his ministerial berth.

TEJASHWI MOCKS NISHANT'S QUALIFICATION

Patna: RJD national president Tejashwi Yadav on Thursday mocked the educational qualification of Health Minister Nishant Kumar, commenting that the Bihar education minister will surely make the JD(U) leader an engineer. Kumar, who was elected to the Legislative Council earlier in the day, had disclosed in his affidavit that at the Birla Institute of Technology, Mesra, he had completed "five out of the eight prescribed semesters up to 2001." The former CM Nitish Kumar's son was earlier dubbed as an engineering graduate like his father. On the question of his qualification, Yadav sarcastically said, "I have full faith in Bihar's education minister that he will make



Nishant Ji an engineer. One individual has become a professor; the other can definitely become an engineer." He was alluding to Bihar minister Ashok Choudhary, who formally became an assistant professor in February, and delivered his first lecture in political science at AN College in Patna the next month.

(PNS)

Now there is seat chori: Priyank Kharge on RS nomination rejection

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

Karnataka Home Minister Priyank Kharge on Thursday alleged "Seat Chori" by the BJP after the rejection of Congress candidate Meenakshi Natarajan's nomination papers for the Rajya Sabha election in Madhya Pradesh. He said the party was moving the Supreme Court against the decision.

The Congress has challenged the Returning Officer's decision to reject Natarajan's nomination and announced that it would seek legal recourse against the move. "First there was 'Vote Chori', and now they (BJP) are trying 'Seat Chori' (theft of Rajya Sabha seat)," Kharge, who is the son of



Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge, told reporters here.

Claiming that the law on the issue was clear, Kharge alleged that the rejection reflected the extent to which the central Government was prepared to go to win elections. "That is why they (BJP) are conducting the Special Intensive Revision (SIR). The law on this matter is very

clear. If they are violating even that, it is a major example of how far (BJP) Governments are willing to go to win an election," he said. The Congress on Wednesday took up with the Election Commission the issue of rejection of its Madhya Pradesh candidate Meenakshi Natarajan's nomination for the Rajya Sabha polls, saying the order was 'egregious' and should be set aside immediately.

A delegation of top party leaders, including K C Venugopal, Jairam Ramesh, Abhishek Singhvi, Vivek Tankha, Randeep Surjewala, Bhupesh Baghel and Deepa Dasmunshi, along with Natarajan, met the Commission and demanded that the decision be reversed.

Sharad Pawar must take lead in merging smaller parties with Congress: Sanjay Raut

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Shiv Sena (UBT) leader Sanjay Raut on Thursday said NCP (SP) president Sharad Pawar should take a lead in merging the smaller parties, which came into existence after splitting away from the Congress, back with the Grand Old Party.

There are leaders who were part of the Congress and Congress-led Governments, and they still espouse the same ideology, he said. "If this (Congress) ideology comes together, then it will pose a big challenge to (Prime Minister) Narendra Modi.

Pawar should take an initiative regarding this," the Rajya Sabha member told reporters. His remarks



come amid a buzz about possible merger of the Trinamool Congress (TMC) with the Congress.

Raut asserted that Congress has to be strong, and leaders of smaller parties that emerged from it must understand the situa-

tion. On Wednesday, Raut had suggested that parties like the TMC and NCP (SP), formed after their leaders quit the Congress, should return to the fold of the Grand Old Party so as to create a strong alternative to the BJP.

Jagan accuses Andhra Govt of recruitment scam, demands CBI probe



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Amaravati

YSRCP supremo YS Jagan Mohan Reddy on Thursday accused the Andhra Pradesh government of conducting a "fraudulent" teacher recruitment process for the DSC-2025 examination and said it lacked standard public accountability measures.

However, Kona Sashidar, Secretary of School Education, said no discrepancy occurred anywhere in DSC-2025 recruitment. Jagan's allegations come in the wake of the Andhra Pradesh government recruiting nearly 16,000 Government teachers through the District Selection Committee (DSC) - 2025 examination last year.

"No merit list, no display, no marks, no ranks, no cut off. Only selected candidates were sent messages and only they got call letters," he told reporters.

Tripartite pact signed to unlock energy reserves along Assam-Nagaland border

TONY DAS
■ New Delhi/ Guwahati

In a significant step towards enhancing India's energy security and achieving greater self-sufficiency in the energy sector, a tripartite agreement on energy exploration and extraction was signed on Thursday in the presence of Union Home Minister Amit Shah, Union Petroleum and Natural Gas Minister Hardeep Singh Puri, Nagaland Chief Minister Neiphiu Rio, and Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma.

The agreement, signed



under the guidance of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, seeks to facilitate exploration and production activities across more than 1,000 square kilometres of land along the Assam-Nagaland border, an area believed to possess substantial energy and mineral reserves.

According to Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma, the pact marks a decisive breakthrough in unlocking the untapped potential of the region. The identified area is expected to offer significant opportunities for hydrocarbon exploration and mineral

extraction, contributing to the country's long-term energy requirements.

Officials believe that the initiative will accelerate investments in the energy sector and create new economic opportunities across the North East.

The agreement is expected to provide fresh momentum to India's pursuit of energy self-reliance, with the North Eastern region emerging as a crucial driver of that vision.

The Centre has consistently emphasised the strategic importance of the North East in national development, particularly in

sectors such as energy, infrastructure, connectivity and trade. The latest initiative aligns with the government's broader objective of reducing dependence on imported energy resources.

Chief Minister Sarma said the agreement reflects the Modi government's commitment to resolving complex and long-pending issues that have historically hindered development and resource utilisation in the region.

He described the pact as an example of cooperative federalism and coordinated efforts between the Centre and state governments to

unlock the economic potential of the North East.

Calling it the beginning of a 'new era' for the Ashtalakshmi region — a term often used to describe the eight North Eastern states — the Assam Chief Minister expressed confidence that the agreement would bring transformative growth and prosperity to the region.

The development is being viewed as a major milestone in strengthening India's energy infrastructure while simultaneously accelerating economic development in the North East.

TN CM Vijay urges action to end child labour, promote education

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay on Thursday called for concerted efforts to end child labour and restore young lives through education.

The state Government's primary objective, he said, is to create a prosperous future by ensuring that children are not engaged in labour, protecting their rights, providing them with quality education, and enabling them to enjoy a happy child-



hood. To achieve this goal, the Government is implementing various proactive schemes aimed at eradicating child labour. "Society and parents should realise that any income earned

through child labour is negligible compared with the long-term benefits of education for both families and the nation," the CM said in a statement on the eve of World Day Against Child Labour.

"Let us support the initiatives of the Tamil Nadu Government to completely eradicate child labour and make the state child labour-free. Let us dismantle the system of child labour and transform the lives of children through education," he added.

Nipah infection reported in Kerala's Kozhikode, 77 contacts identified

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Kozhikode

A Nipah virus infection case has been confirmed in Kozhikode district, prompting the administration to initiate preventive measures on Thursday.

The infection was confirmed in a 43-year-old man from Ramanattukara, Kozhikode District Collector M S Madhavikutty said. A Government press release said the patient is undergoing treatment in the ICU of Kozhikode Medical College Hospital.

According to the collector, 77 people have been identified in the contact list of the infected individual. They include 58 healthcare workers, 14 family members, and five friends and colleagues. None of the contacts has reported any symptoms



so far, the statement said. Of the 77 contacts, two have been classified in the highest-risk category, 13 in the high-risk category, and 62 in the low-risk category. All those in the highest-risk and high-risk categories have been placed under quarantine, the statement said.

Pilots' body renews demand for judicial probe into AI-171 crash, opposes interim report release

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ahmedabad

The Federation of Indian Pilots (FIP) on Thursday renewed its demand for a judicial probe into the AI-171 crash and urged authorities not to release any interim investigation report, saying it would create further confusion and speculation.

Addressing a press conference on the eve of the first anniversary of the aviation tragedy, FIP president C S Randhawa said the association wants the Aircraft Accident Investigation Bureau (AAIB) to release a final report only after completing a comprehensive investigation. He also alleged that the ongoing probe has several shortcomings and has unfairly shifted focus towards the pilots. On June 12, 2025, the London-



bound AI-171 flight crashed into the BJ Medical College hostel in Ahmedabad's Meghaninagar, killing 260 persons, including 241 on board and 19 on the ground. Only one passenger survived.

Referring to media reports suggesting the AAIB may soon issue an interim report, Randhawa said such a move would create further

confusion and speculation.

"If there is no conclusion from the investigation, releasing an interim report will only lead to more misunderstandings. The final report should be issued whenever the probe is completed," he said. The FIP, which represents over 5,400 pilots and aviation professionals, has already

approached the Supreme Court seeking a judicial probe into the crash. He reiterated that a judicial probe is necessary.

Randhawa alleged that the AAIB's preliminary report, released in July last year, led to speculation about pilot error after it referred to the movement of fuel control switches. "The Western media immediately built a suicide theory around a brief cockpit voice recorder transcript.

We strongly condemned those reports. It is too premature to blame the pilots," he said. He claimed that the Boeing aircraft had a history of technical issues, including a stabiliser defect and problems linked to pressurisation and air-conditioning systems, before operating the ill-fated flight. According to Randhawa, the investigation has not adequately

examined the possibility of electrical system failures on the Boeing 787 aircraft.

"Our stand from day one has been that there were electrical issues which need a thorough investigation. No pilot touched the fuel control switches.

The fuel supply may have been cut off because of electrical failures affecting aircraft systems," he alleged. He also questioned why the lone survivor, Vishwash Kumar Ramesh, was reportedly interviewed by investigators nearly 10 months after the crash.

"He was the only survivor and could have provided crucial evidence. Yet he was questioned much later, while efforts were allegedly made to investigate the mental health of the pilots soon after the accident," Randhawa said. The FIP president further

AIR INDIA STAFF TO OBSERVE 2-MIN SILENCE TODAY

New Delhi: Air India staff will observe a two-minute silence at their workstations on Friday as a mark of respect for those who passed away in the fatal crash of its plane on June 12 last year. "Employees may observe this moment at their workstations; those at airport check-in counters or engaged in essential ground or flight duties may continue their responsibilities as required," the airline said in an e-mail to the staff. The two-minute silence will

be observed from 1:39 pm to 1:41 pm (IST). Air India's Boeing 787-8 or Dreamliner with registration VT-ANB enroute to London Gatwick crashed soon after takeoff on June 12, 2025, killing 241 people onboard and 19 on the ground. One passenger survived while all 12 crew members died in the accident that happened during the initial climb. Among the passengers who died were citizens from the UK, Portugal, and Canada.

(PNS)

claimed that several messages, in the form of numerical codes, relating to the aircraft's health monitoring systems were transmitted to Boeing and Air India before the crash and should be examined by investigators.

He also criticised the composition of the investigation team, alleging that more subject matter experts, including experienced pilots, engineers and flight safety specialists, should have been included in the probe.



Editor's
TAKE

US courts hit Trump's immigrant war

A federal judge has struck down Trump's \$100K H-1B visa fee, giving relief to millions of skilled workers applying to work in the US

In a ruling that reverberated from Silicon Valley to Bengaluru, a federal judge in Boston's District Court for Massachusetts vacated President Trump's September 2025 Presidential Proclamation that had imposed a staggering \$100,000 fee on every new H-1B visa petition. The verdict was unambiguous: the President had imposed a tax without Congress's consent, and that is simply unconstitutional.

The fee was framed by the administration as a guardian of the American worker. Trump himself argued the steep price tag would ensure only the "truly extraordinary" would qualify. The logic was seductive in its simplicity: make it expensive, and only the best will try. But the logic collapsed under legal scrutiny. The court ruled that what the White House called a "regulatory payment" was, in substance, a revenue-raising mechanism - a tax in all but name. The power to levy taxes belongs to Congress, not the Oval Office. In striking it down, the court also cited violations of the Administrative Procedure Act and the constitutional separation of powers.

The collateral damage of the fee, had it stood, would have been enormous. Universities such as Stanford, Michigan, and the University of Florida - each receiving more than a hundred H-1B approvals annually - faced a severe hiring crunch for researchers and faculty. Hospitals reliant on foreign-trained doctors and nurses were equally exposed. Twenty Democratic state attorneys general had sued on precisely these grounds: that public institutions, from schools to clinics, could not absorb a six-figure surcharge per hire.

For small and mid-sized technology companies, the fee was not a deterrent but a door slammed shut. For India, the stakes were highest. Indian nationals are, year after year, the single largest group of H-1B recipients. The fee threatened to make hiring Indian engineers, scientists, and healthcare workers economically indefensible for most employers, effectively pricing an entire nationality out of the American labour market.

Monday's ruling offers that community a window of relief, but it is not a clear sky yet. And that is the crucial caveat. This is not the Supreme Court speaking, and this is not the final word. The Trump administration is widely expected to appeal, and a parallel lawsuit filed by the US Chamber of Commerce in Washington, DC, is still working its way through the system. A third case filed in San Francisco by religious and labour groups adds yet another front. The possibility of conflicting rulings across three appellate circuits makes a Supreme Court hearing increasingly likely. What remains is a legal and political battlefield. The administration could yet seek a stay pending appeal, which would immediately restore the fee.

What the Boston ruling does establish, loudly and clearly, is that immigration policy cannot be made by proclamation when it amounts to taxation. For India's vast technology diaspora and the global talent pipeline that feeds American innovation, this is a moment of relief - earned by the courts, not by politics. But relief, in this climate, must be mistaken for nothing more than a pause.

DIGITAL EXPERIENCE

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The new Bengal and my nationalist journey

With courage, clarity and commitment to national interest, West Bengal can once again emerge as a beacon of culture, prosperity and civilisational confidence for the entire nation



SUKHENDU
SEKHAR RAY

Having spent more than five decades observing the social, cultural and political evolution of West Bengal, I feel compelled to share my concerns about the direction in which our beloved state has travelled. My journey began in Malda during my formative years at school and continued through my college days in Kolkata. Those experiences gave me an intimate understanding of Bengal's rich civilisational heritage, its cultural ethos and its unique way of life.

I had the privilege of being closely associated with the late Bharat Ratna Pranab Mukherjee, former President of India, one of India's finest statesmen and a son of Bengal whose unwavering commitment to national unity and democratic values inspired generations. His deep understanding of India's civilisational roots and constitutional framework shaped many of my own views on public life.

Over the past half-century, I have witnessed profound changes in West Bengal. Many of these changes have been positive, including advancements in education, infrastructure and democratic participation. However, I have also seen developments that, in my view, have weakened the cultural foundations that once defined Bengali society.

One of the most significant concerns has been the large-scale migration from Bangladesh over several decades. While humanitarian considerations must always remain important, the absence of effective border management and the politicisation of migration have, in my opinion, created serious demographic, social and administrative challenges. The issue has often been discussed through partisan lenses rather than through the broader framework of national interest, social stability and the rule of law.

The consequences, as I have observed them, extend beyond the frontiers of electoral politics. They touch upon questions of identity, cultural continuity, employment, public resources and national security. Bengal's indigenous cultural traditions, nurtured over the centuries, have gradually faced pressures that many ordinary citizens feel uncomfortable discussing openly.

I still remember a Bengal where *bhajans*, *kirtans*, local festivals and community gatherings formed an integral part of social life. These traditions were not merely religious practices; they were expressions of Bengali civilisation and cultural harmony. They represented the values of tolerance, learning, spirituality and community bonding that shaped generations of Bengalis.



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Member of Parliament,
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 The Pioneer

polarisation, ordinary citizens have often paid the highest price. The peace-loving Bengali, who traditionally valued education, culture and social harmony, has frequently found himself caught between competing political interests.

Another concern frequently voiced by citizens is the issue of religious conversion and the perceived erosion of traditional social structures. These are sensitive matters that require careful and balanced discussion. However, it is important that public institutions protect both individual freedoms and the cultural rights of communities that have historically contributed to Bengal's identity.

The current political atmosphere in West Bengal reflects the accumulated frustrations of many citizens. The growing demand for accountability, development, employment, security and cultural confidence is not an isolated phenomenon. It is the result of years of accumulated grievances and unmet aspirations.

It is in this context that I arrived at an important personal and political decision. After long and laboured reflection, I concluded that Bengal required a renewed commitment to nationalism, development, cultural self-confidence and good governance. I believe that the nationalist movement led by Prime Minister Narendra Modi has articulated many of these aspirations in a manner that resonates with large sections of the population.

My inclination to associate myself with this broader nationalist movement is rooted not in narrow political expediency but in deep and abiding conviction. I believe that India's unity, integrity, security and development must remain paramount.

I also believe that Bengal can reclaim its historic role as a leader in national life by embracing economic growth, transparent governance, cultural pride and social cohesion. This is not a call for division. It is a call for renewal. It is a call to preserve the best of Bengal's traditions while preparing confidently for the future. The Bengal of Swami Vivekananda, Rabindranath Tagore, Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyay, Subhas Chandra Bose, Syama Prasad Mookerjee and countless other luminaries deserves a future worthy of its extraordinary heritage.

The task before us is immense, but so is the strength of the Bengali people. With courage, clarity and commitment to national interest, West Bengal can once again emerge as a beacon of culture, prosperity and civilisational confidence for the entire nation. Here, I am irresistibly emboldened to strike a note of optimism by drawing upon the words of Pranab Mukherjee, uttered on March 7, 2010: "I am confident that although the state has temporarily fallen somewhat behind, it will regain its lost glory and earn its due respect."

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

Are we raising winners or kind human beings?



SAKSHI SETHI

2ND OPINION

In our relentless pursuit of raising successful children, we have quietly forgotten something essential: the art of generosity. Trophies, grades and rankings dominate childhood today, but rarely do we pause to ask: are we nurturing achievers, or are we nurturing human beings?

A simple story offers a powerful answer. When a child asks another for an apple, the child holding two takes a bite from both. It appears selfish until he offers one and says, "Take this one; it is sweeter." What looked like greed was actually thoughtfulness. He tested both to give away the better one. This small act captures something profound: true generosity is not about giving what is left over or unwanted. It is about giving with care, warmth and dignity.

Today's childhood is built almost entirely around achievement. Schools reward the highest scorers, parents stress over every grade, and society celebrates those who finish first. Ambition, of course, has its place, but when children are taught to view every peer as a rival, something quietly breaks inside them. A child who only learns to win may never learn to share the victory.

The absence of generosity does not always look like cruelty. It hides in smaller moments: refusing to share notes, laughing at a classmate's mistake, or feeling quietly pleased when a peer stumbles. These habits seem minor, but they harden over time. The child who hoards today may become the professional who withholds opportunities tomorrow.

Generosity is not a soft, optional virtue. It is a life skill. It builds relationships, strengthens communities and creates the kind of emotional security that no academic score can provide. When empathy and sharing are nurtured early, they grow into cooperative colleagues, ethical leaders and compassionate citizens.

Social media has made this harder. Children and adults are constantly surrounded by curated images of success, beauty and achievement, fuelling comparison, insecurity and an instinct to guard rather than give. Human connection is slowly becoming transactional, and warmth is increasingly treated as a weakness rather than a strength.

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

Schools and families must both take responsibility. Education cannot be limited to producing high scorers. A child who excels at mathematics but lacks kindness has received an incomplete education. Equally, parents need to reflect on the messages they send. When achievement is constantly framed as a race against others, children begin to see companions as competitors.

Ambition must be balanced with the understanding that real success means helping others grow alongside you. This lesson extends well into adulthood. Workplaces and communities suffer when people hesitate to share credit, knowledge or opportunity. Many are quick to seek support in difficult times but reluctant to offer it when others begin to rise. A society cannot truly progress when every individual is focused solely on protecting personal interests.

The extra apple, then, is a mirror. It asks us to look honestly at the spirit behind our giving. Do we share only when we have more than enough? Do we help only when it costs us nothing? Do we offer others the sweeter apple, or only the one we no longer want? The world will always admire sharp minds. But it is sustained, quietly and steadily, by gentler hearts.

The writer is an educator and a councillor

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Bengal's political recalibration

The internal rifts within the Trinamool Congress (TMC) indicate a larger shift in West Bengal's political landscape. Reports of dissatisfaction among several leaders have raised questions about the party's cohesion. The emergence of dissenting voices suggests that some leaders want a greater role in decision-making, challenging Mamata Banerjee's authority. Against this backdrop, a possible alliance or even a merger between the TMC and the Congress is being discussed. While many Congress leaders remain uncomfortable with the idea due to the long history of rivalry between the two parties, such a move would represent a major political realignment in the state. Any partnership would likely be driven by electoral considerations, as both parties seek to strengthen their position in an increasingly competitive political environment.

However, significant ideological and organisational hurdles remain. Moreover, any prospective alliance is unlikely to alter the broader political balance immediately, as the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) continues to enjoy a strong national presence. The coming months will reveal whether opposition unity can evolve into a credible political challenge or remain a subject of speculation.

ABHILASH SHRIVASTAVA | UJJAIN

Muzaffarabad at a crossroads

The unrest in Muzaffarabad is not a sudden development. Decades of political manipulation, high electricity tariffs and Islamabad's reluctance to allow genuine self-governance in Pakistan-administered Kashmir have created deep resentment. Under such conditions, even a movement centred on flour subsidies could escalate into a wider public agitation.

The demands of the Joint Awami Action Committee (JAAC) are fundamentally civic in nature. Banning the movement and placing bounties on its leaders has only intensified public anger and attracted international attention to Pakistan's democratic shortcomings in the region. The editorial's advice to India deserves careful consideration. Triumphant reactions would be counterproductive. India's long-term interests are better served by maintaining a principled and consistent position. This includes highlighting the concerns of the people of Pakistan-occupied Kashmir in international forums, engaging the diaspora through legitimate channels, and ensuring exemplary governance in Jammu and Kashmir. Infrastructure, democratic institutions and economic opportunities speak louder than rhetoric. India's moral authority on this issue depends on what it builds and sustains at home.

SM JEEVA | CHENNAI

Bharathiraja lives through his films

The passing of Bharathiraja marks the end of a remarkable chapter in Indian cinema. Alongside K Balachander and Balu Mahendra, he formed a legendary trio that transformed modern Tamil cinema through innovation and artistic excellence.

Bharathiraja's contribution was extraordinary. Through films such as 16 Vayathinile, Muthal Mariyathai, Sigappu Rojakkal and Alaigal Oivathillai, he brought the essence of rural Tamil Nadu to the silver screen. His storytelling captured the emotions, struggles and aspirations of ordinary people with authenticity, making his films timeless.

Equally important was his role as a mentor. He introduced and nurtured numerous actors and actresses who later became some of the industry's most celebrated stars. His eye for talent and ability to shape careers remain unmatched.

I vividly remember meeting him during a corporate engagement. When I asked for his business card, he smiled and replied, "Bharathiraja does not need a business card." That response reflected the stature he had earned through decades of excellence.

Indian cinema has lost a giant, but his legacy will continue to inspire generations.

AP THIRUVADI | CHENNAI

FIVE TRILLION DOLLAR DREAM REMAINS UNFULFILLED TODAY

The target of transforming India into a five-trillion-dollar economy has missed yet another deadline. In September 2018, Prime Minister Narendra Modi announced the goal, setting 2022 as the target year. When that deadline passed, the government revised the timeline to FY 2024-25.

However, the GDP data released this week shows that the target remains unmet. India's GDP stands at around ₹346.4 lakh crore, equivalent to approximately \$3.6 trillion. Following these missed deadlines, references to the five-trillion-dollar goal have become noticeably less frequent in official statements and public forums.

The Prime Minister had also highlighted India's expected rise to become the world's third-largest economy. Yet recent economic indicators suggest that India remains outside the top three

economies globally. Similar trends have been observed in the stock market rankings, where India has also slipped in recent months.

Supporters of the previous UPA government point out that India's GDP growth in dollar terms was stronger between 2004 and 2014 than during the past decade. They argue that the depreciation of the rupee has reduced the economy's size when measured in dollar terms.

A stronger manufacturing base, greater investment in advanced technologies, reduced energy dependence and higher levels of stable foreign direct investment could have helped strengthen economic growth. The missed target highlights the challenges that remain on India's path towards becoming a five-trillion-dollar economy.

BHAGWAN THADANI | MUMBAI

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

From Mithila to the world: Modi’s 4,399 days and Bihar’s quiet transformation

Guided by the vision of Viksit Bharat 2047, the Modi government’s Act East and Purvodaya policies have repositioned the Northeast from the geographic periphery to a gateway of national growth



SANJAY KUMAR JHA

democratic journey - one that speaks as much to the depth of popular trust as it does to the consistency of purposeful governance.

The NDA’s third consecutive mandate under his leadership is not merely a symbol of political continuity. It is an affirmation of a transformative journey that has connected large parts of India, particularly Bihar and the Northeast, to the mainstream of national development. That Prime Minister Modi has reached this landmark without the advantage of inherited political legacy, rising instead through determination, hard work, and the sustained trust of the people, makes the achievement all the more meaningful.

This milestone also carries a historical dimension. In surpassing the record of India’s first Prime Minister Pandit Jawaharlal Nehru, Prime Minister Modi has done so in a political environment far more diverse and competitive than the one Nehru governed in, when the Congress party held near-unchallenged dominance over national life.

For much of the twentieth century, Bihar’s immense potential went largely unrecognised despite its central role in the nation’s political and cultural history. Over the past two decades, under the stewardship of former Chief Minister Nitish Kumar and through twelve years of Prime Minister Modi’s leadership at the Centre, the state has witnessed a quiet but consequential transformation. Bihar is no longer spoken of primarily in terms of its challenges. It has entered the national conversation as a state of growing opportunity, expanding possibility, and deep cultural richness.

It is a matter of particular pride that Prime Minister Modi has consistently worked to place Bihar’s cultural heritage on the global stage. Mithila painting stands as perhaps the finest example of this commitment. Once an art form confined to the walls of homes and village courtyards, it has today become a recognised symbol of India’s civilisational identity, finding its way to prestigious platforms across the world. Each time the Prime Minister presents Madhubani-inspired gifts to heads of state and distinguished visitors, he is not merely offering a work of art. He is introducing the world to the creative consciousness, living traditions, and cultural spirit of Mithila.

The story of Mithila Makhana follows a similar arc. For years, it remained a familiar but largely local agricultural product. Today, it is steadily earning a distinct identity in global markets as a nutritional superfood.

The Geographical Indication tag provided formal recognition of its uniqueness and value, while the announcement of a dedicated Makhana Board in the Union Budget signalled a meaningful policy commitment to transforming local produce into a global brand. Together, these initiatives have opened new avenues of livelihood and income for thousands of families across Mithila.

One of the defining characteristics of Prime Minister Modi’s approach to governance has been his conviction that development cannot be reduced to roads, bridges, and digital infrastructure alone. He has sought to weave cultural heritage, traditional knowledge, local products, and tourism into the broader fabric of national progress.

This is why places such as Ayodhya, Kashi, Kedarnath, and the cultural centres of the Northeast have received renewed attention and investment. Mithila, the sacred land associated with Mata Sita, has similarly found a stronger and more assured place in both the national and international imagination.

Under his leadership, India has established itself on the world stage not only as a rapidly growing economic power but also as a civilisational and cultural force of consequence. From yoga and Ayurveda to

In a democracy, the true measure of time is not the turning of calendar pages but the transformation it brings to people’s lives. Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s completion of 4,399 consecutive days as an elected Prime Minister marks a significant milestone in the country’s



The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

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Madhubani art and Makhana, there has been a sustained and deliberate effort to convert India’s diverse cultural strengths into instruments of global engagement and soft power.

India’s foreign policy has undergone an equally significant transformation. On the question of terrorism, India’s voice today is clearer, more confident, and more consequential than at any previous point. The all-party parliamentary delegations dispatched to various countries following Operation Sindoor gave expression to this resolve. Their purpose was to help the international community understand India’s concerns and its unwavering commitment to combating terrorism in all its forms.

I had the privilege of leading one such delegation. In meetings with policymakers, parliamentarians, analysts, and media representatives across several countries, I witnessed firsthand the seriousness with which India’s perspective is now received and the respect it commands. This transformation is not the product of a single moment. It reflects a consistent, proactive, and far-sighted diplomatic strategy pursued with discipline over more than a decade.

History will, in its own time, render its verdict on every government and every leader. Yet it is difficult to dispute that over the past decade, India has experienced a meaningful shift in its self-confidence, global standing, and developmental ambition.

Guided by the vision of Viksit Bharat 2047, the Modi government’s Act East and Purvodaya policies have repositioned the Northeast from the geographic periphery to a gateway of national growth. Enhanced road, rail, and air connectivity has not only accelerated economic activity across the region but deepened national integration in ways that were long overdue.

For Bihar, which has historically contended with significant developmental constraints, this period has been especially consequential. The state has received enhanced economic support in successive Union Budgets, with sustained initiatives spanning infrastructure expansion, new expressways and bridges, railway modernisation, airport development, and the strengthening of its agriculture-based economy.

The effective coordination between the NDA governments at the Centre and in the state has enabled Bihar to steadily scale new heights. I remain confident that, building on the foundation of good governance and infrastructure-led growth established under former Chief Minister Nitish Kumar, Bihar will continue to gather momentum in the years ahead.

Prime Minister Modi’s record of 4,399 consecutive days as an elected Prime Minister is, in the end, far more than a statistical achievement. It represents trust, continuity, and the kind of visionary leadership that endures because it delivers. More than anything, it reflects a transformative process that has given large parts of India, and Bihar in particular, new opportunities, a renewed sense of identity, and greater possibilities for the future. In a democracy, that remains the most enduring measure of successful leadership.

Empowering India’s Youth for a Viksit Bharat



MANOJ TIWARI

India for the demands of the 21st century. If Macaulay’s education model was intended to serve an empire, the NEP seeks to equip India’s youth to lead a nation aspiring to become a developed country by 2047. The contrast is striking. While the colonial-era framework focused on uniformity and memorisation, the NEP emphasises critical thinking, creativity, innovation, flexibility and multidisciplinary learning. It is the first major overhaul of India’s education system in 34 years and is widely regarded as one of the most ambitious reforms undertaken in independent India.

The impact of this transformation is increasingly visible across India’s higher education landscape. A decade ago, access to quality higher education remained a challenge for millions of students, particularly those from smaller towns and rural regions. Limited institutions, inadequate seats and geographical disparities often restricted opportunities and aspirations. Today, the scale of expansion is difficult to ignore.

The number of universities in India has risen from 723 in 2014 to 1,213 in 2024, while Higher Education Institutions (HEIs) have expanded from about 51,500 to nearly 59,000. This growth has been driven by the implementation of NEP 2020, the establishment of new Central Universities and Institutions of National Importance, and flagship programmes such as PM-USHA and the Rashtriya Uchchatar Shiksha Abhiyan (RUSA). The growth is not merely numerical. India today has 23 Indian Institutes of Technology (IITs), 22 Indian Institutes of Management (IIMs) and 20 All India Institutes of Medical Sciences (AIIMS). The opening of IIT campuses in Abu Dhabi and Zanzibar signals India’s growing academic footprint beyond its borders and its emergence as a global knowledge partner.

At the heart of the NEP is a move away from rigid academic structures. Students are no longer expected to remain confined within fixed streams of science, commerce or humanities. Multiple entry and exit options, multidisciplinary curricula and credit transfers through the Academic Bank of Credits are designed to allow learners to tailor educational pathways according to their interests and career aspirations. The Academic Bank of Credits has emerged as one of the most significant reforms under the policy. Covering more than 2,600 institutions and issuing over 4.6 crore student IDs, it allows learners to accumulate, store and transfer academic credits across institutions. More than 150 universities have already adopted flexible admission and exit mechanisms aligned with the NEP framework. Another major objective of the policy is to improve participation in higher education.

The NEP has set a target of achieving a Gross Enrolment Ratio (GER) of 50 per cent in higher education by 2035. To achieve this, it envisages adding 3.5 crore new seats across universities and colleges. Recent figures indicate that progress is already underway. Student enrolment in higher education increased from 4.33 crore in 2021-22 to 4.46 crore in 2022-23, reflecting expanding access across regions, communities and socio-economic groups. Research and innovation form another cornerstone of the reforms. The establishment of the Anusandhan National Research Foundation seeks to strengthen India’s research ecosystem, encourage collaboration between academia and industry, and promote scientific inquiry across disciplines. Programmes such as MERITE are aimed at improving the quality and relevance of technical education while fostering innovation and entrepreneurship.

The policy also seeks to internationalise Indian higher education. New regulations permit twinning, joint and dual-degree programmes with foreign universities, while several international institutions are exploring opportunities to establish campuses in India. The larger objective is to position India as a global education destination and reduce the outflow of students seeking quality education abroad. Beyond universities and classrooms, the reforms are closely linked to India’s broader developmental ambitions. Education, skills, innovation and employability are increasingly viewed as the building blocks of economic growth and global competitiveness. Initiatives promoting vocational education, artificial intelligence, digital learning, startups and industry-academia collaboration reflect the changing nature of work in a technology-driven world. The significance of these reforms becomes even greater in the context of Viksit Bharat@2047, the national vision of transforming India into a developed nation by the centenary of Independence. Policymakers recognise that demographic advantage alone will not guarantee prosperity. India’s young population must be equipped with world-class skills, research capabilities and entrepreneurial abilities if the country is to emerge as a global leader in manufacturing, technology, healthcare, innovation and services.

The NEP is therefore more than an education reform; it is a nation-building project. By expanding access, encouraging multidisciplinary learning, strengthening research, promoting innovation and creating a culture of lifelong learning, it seeks to build the human capital that will drive India’s next phase of growth. Challenges undoubtedly remain. Ensuring uniform implementation across states, improving faculty quality, strengthening research funding and bridging regional disparities will require sustained effort and investment. Yet the direction of change is unmistakable. If Macaulay’s education system served the needs of a colonial administration, the National Education Policy seeks to create a generation capable of shaping India’s future. The journey from producing clerks to nurturing creators, scientists, innovators and entrepreneurs may be long, but India appears firmly committed to that transformation. As the country moves towards its Viksit Bharat@2047 goals, the success of the NEP could well determine whether India merely participates in the global knowledge economy or helps lead it.



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Remembering AI-171: Tragedy, loss and unanswered questions



SANJAY LAZAR

years as the world has passed us by, the dreadful memories of that Boeing 747 strewn over the Atlantic Ocean off Ireland still jar the mind, when this B-787 turned into a fireball at Ahmedabad and brought us crashing down to earth to reality.

That afternoon, I got a call from a friend in engineering, and watched the forwarded video in horror, literally within minutes, TV channels were scrambling to verify facts. It was Indian aviation’s worst nightmare, a wide body tragedy that likely had killed all on board and worse still, had ploughed into a medical college on ground, killing many more.

When all was done and dusted, 260 people had perished in that inferno, 241 passenger and crew, and 19 innocents on the ground. Miraculously, one person survived and was found talking on the phone walking away, a halo of invincibility surrounded him.

The scale of grief stunned the politicians and Indian public, it was India’s first live air tragedy, that disgustingly got converted into a social media soap, where millions of us, vicariously

The Air India 171 disaster has become one of India’s worst Aviation tragedies, and Air India’s first wide body crash since the Kanishka bombing of Air India 182 back in June of 1985.

Time has stood still in those 40

viewed the drama daily, oblivious of the pain of the families they left behind. So, what really happened to AI-171? was it a technical glitch? was it an engine failure? or a FADEC failure? Was it sabotage, as some uselessly speculated? Was its Pilot suicide as we are led to believe? Why was the world’s third largest aviation nation so clueless about how to go forth in this tragedy of epic proportions? Why was the entire investigation shrouded in a veil of such secrecy, that even high-level persons in the ministry and airline, were kept out of the proceedings.?

As Air India grieved for its dead, the nation mourned with the families, and cried with those we lost. For me it was truly personal, as I knew Sumeet since a little after he joined IGRUA, I also knew the two senior cabin crew Shraddha Dhavan & Aparna Mahadik personally, having been with Air India for so long, everything that happens there, automatically becomes personal.

The preliminary report released to the world, appeared to be a real hatchet job, without even having proper subject matter experts. The report raised more questions than it answered, and Pilots and experts, shook their heads in disbelief as the report tried to give a clean chit to the Aircraft and engine makers rather than delve deeper into the reasons for the accident.

The cryptic one line in the report, which is neither a quote, nor is the complete narration, merely states “In the cockpit voice recording, one of the pilots is heard asking the other why did he cutoff. The other pilot responded that he did not do so”

It does not speak of details, but is deftly manoeuvred to create a shroud of suspicion



around one pilot at least, and deflect attention from the most obvious question, was this on the basis of some technical aircraft or other fault? If not, then this it raises the obvious and central question, if the CVR was retrieved, and one sentence paraphrased, then why was the entire transcript not released? Was was it done to distract the focus of the world, through outrage and anger ?

In many ways, the scenes playing out were reminiscent of Lion Air 610, way back in October 2018, when it primarily blamed Captain Suneja’s pilot error. It took the crash of Ethiopian Airlines 302 a few months later that prompted the worldwide grounding of all 737 max aircraft and a relook at the entire problem. The final report of Lion Air 610 listed 9 contributory factors, which focussed on MCAS; AoA; Sensor and software issues, but moved away from Pilot error.

We all wonder whether AI-171 bears a similar tale, or could it have, as WSJ & other western media speculate, been a case of a German Wings? Hold that thought -Let me put the speculation to rest,

“I knew Sumeet, and flew with him”, I also spoke to his batch mates and friends, “I don’t for a moment believe that he could ever do something like that, in fact, neither pilot would”.

A recent TV interview by one Romin Vohra, who lost three of his family members in the 171 tragedies, states that he entered the morgue, and in one section, he saw a pilot’s body, bent over holding a part of the yoke (central column). He also saw other bodies, as he tried to identify his niece and family. There has been no denial by any authorities or the AAIB of this account, nor has there been any confirmation, leading to much more mystery. The post mortem of Capt Sumeet is not available publicly to confirm these reports and hence such speculation must remain inconclusive.

Rachel Chitra an investigative journalist, has this month in a special report quoted an unnamed source from the AAIB, who allegedly stated that “The preliminary report was a negotiated deal between Air India, Tata, GE and Boeing-GE to a lesser extent,” which is exactly what some of us said eleven months ago, when the preliminary report was released. It seemed designed purely to allay the fears of US Big corporations and the 1400 odd 787’s flying in the skies. There was absolutely no reason for an accident investigation board in a sovereign nation, to give a clean chit to an aircraft maker and an engine manufacturer in another country, when it had not even released the transcript of the CVR, leave alone delve deeper into the systemic issues that had plagued the manufacturer or any other issues that many others have flagged. One year on, many speculated, but I did not expect the AAIB to present a final

report on AI-171. We are no closer to the truth today than we were on July 12 2025. India has embarrassed itself in the comity of global aviation with subterfuge, questionable practices and a system beset with a regulator with questionable morals, and an AAIB that doesn’t seem to function coherently. One hopes that the new DG will cleanse the aegean stables of inherited muck.

India has to repair its system and it’s a job that the Prime Minister will need to look into deeply, that the world’s fastest growing aviation system, has people who are incompetent and some who are rotten to the core. It’s time for the government to cleanse the regulator, bring in an independent CAA and allow our accident investigation board to operate independently, have a transparent release of the findings of AI-171 and lets all learn to move on with our lives.

Air India for its part, has maintained a highly dignified silence and grieved alone. In many ways, AI-171 could be the heartbreaking turning point for Air India. The Tatas have faced bigger challenges before and Air Indians are a tough resilient bunch, and will bounce back stronger and higher, I know them well.

We owe it to the dead and their families, to our citizens, to give them the truth, in a transparent fashion, however bitter it might be, even if it’s what we never wanted to accept or hear, we will have to do so, our nations credibility depends on it.

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Nirav Modi fraud case moved to Magistrate Court

A special CBI court here on Thursday transferred an alleged fraud case against absconding diamond businessman Nirav Modi to the magistrate's court after the CBI stated that corruption charges could not be proved against officials of the Punjab National Bank. This case against Modi, directors of firms linked to him, and unknown officials of the PNB was registered by the central agency following a complaint filed by the bank's Mumbai zonal office. As per the complaint, the bank was cheated of ₹321.88 crore as credit facilities given to Modi's firms were misused.

During an internal inquiry, the bank found circular transactions between Nirav Modi-promoted partnership firms, namely Solar Exports, Stellar diamonds and Diamond R US, and Modi-promoted Firestar International Ltd. (FIL) and Firestar Diamonds International Pvt Ltd (FDIPL), the complaint claimed.

The accused were initially booked under Sections 120-B (criminal conspiracy) read with 420 (cheating) of the Indian Penal Code (IPC), along with Section 13(2) of the Prevention of Corruption Act, 1988. However, the CBI on Thursday told the court that a thorough investigation yielded no incriminating material under the Prevention of Corruption Act against either the PNB officials or private individuals.

(PTI)



2020 Delhi riots: Verdict in IB officer murder case deferred

A Delhi court on Thursday deferred its verdict in the sensational murder case of Intelligence Bureau officer Ankit Sharma, who was killed during the northeast Delhi riots in 2020, to July 7. Additional Sessions Judge Praveen Singh was hearing the case against 11 accused, including former AAP councillor Tahir Hussain.

The case pertains to an FIR registered at Dayalpur police station on the complaint of Ravinder Kumar, father of Ankit Sharma. According to the complaint, Sharma, who was posted with the Intelligence Bureau, had returned home from office on February 25, 2020, before stepping out again. When he did not return for a long time, his family began searching for him, only to be informed by locals that their son had been killed and his body thrown into the Khajuri Khas drain near a mosque in the Chand Bagh Pulia area.

(PTI)



Strict enforcement of PCPNDT Act needed: SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Decrying the deep-seated patriarchal preference for a male child and the "behind-the-curtains" prevalence of sex-selection practices, the Supreme Court on Thursday said strict enforcement of the Pre-Conception and Pre-Natal Diagnostic Techniques (PCPNDT) Act is needed till the time there is a change of mentality.

A bench of Justices Sanjay Karol and Prashant Kumar Mishra noted there were various schemes for the girl child, such as "Beti Bachao Beti Padhao, Janani Suraksha Yojana, Ladli Lakshmi Yojana", that are indicative of continued efforts to eradicate the systemic bias suffered by girls in an inherently patriarchal system.

It said much progress has been made, and yet, much is left to be desired.

"Consequently, the integrity and strict enforcement of



welfare-oriented legislation such as the PCPNDT Act remain essential along with efforts continued and earnest, till the time there is a widespread change in mentality and what, till now, is perceived as the 'inherent weakness' of the woman, is replaced by true equality, when there will dawn a realisation that efforts such as these are no longer required. This is not to say that the laws protecting women within legislation such as IPC/BNS will no longer be required, but at least, there will no longer be a question on



Indian judiciary promotes mediation: CJI

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Indian judiciary has promoted mediation not only as an alternative but as a robust dispute resolution mechanism, Chief Justice of India Surya Kant said during a panel discussion conducted by the Indian High Commission in London.

Stating that mediation was very close to his heart, the CJI said that the Supreme Court Legal Service Committee (SCLSC) has created a huge team of trained mediators.

"I can say proudly that in every town, in every street (in India) people know what mediation is," the CJI said.

The High Commission in London on Wednesday

hosted a high-level panel discussion on "Technology and the Future of Mediation" and brought together leading judicial and legal figures from India and the United Kingdom, according to a press statement.

Besides the CJI, the panel featured Lord Hamblen of Kersey, Judge of the UK Supreme Court; Kirsty Brimelow KC, President of the Bar Council of England and Wales; and Brett Dixon, Vice President of the Law Society of England and Wales.

High Commissioner Kumaran P made the opening remarks. The discussion was moderated by Tanvi Dubey, Advocate-on-Record of the Supreme Court.

Speaking on the role of



CJI Surya Kant, second left, in a photograph during a high-level panel discussion hosted by the Indian High Commission in London

the judiciary in promoting mediation, the CJI outlined the evolution of mediation in India, dividing it into two phases: that is, before and after the enactment of the Mediation Act, 2023.

The CJI said that before the legislation came into force, courts had actively encouraged mediation as a robust dispute resolution mechanism. Referring to his early years as a high court judge in 2004, he highlighted the establishment of mediation centres at the trial court, high court and Supreme Court levels.

"The Mediation Act, 2023 is the culmination of a statutory and judicially created regime that has evolved over decades," he said. The CJI

highlighted judicial initiatives aimed at building mediation capacity, including mandatory training programmes for mediators through State Judicial Academies and the role of the National Legal Services Authority and Lok Adalats in familiarising citizens with consensual dispute resolution mechanisms.

Responding to a question on whether mediation should be preferred over arbitration, the CJI emphasised that both mechanisms have important roles to play.

"I do not discourage arbitration," he said, adding that growing commercial engagement between nations inevitably generates disputes.

ED challenges HC order in NewsClick PMLA case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Enforcement Directorate has decided to challenge in the Supreme Court a Delhi High Court's order that quashed a money laundering case against news portal NewsClick and its editor-in-chief, Prabir Purkayastha, on charges of violation of FDI rules, officials said on Thursday.



VJAYAN HAILS DELHI HC VERDICT IN NEWSCLICK CASE

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thiruvananthapuram

Leader of Opposition in the Kerala Assembly, Pinarayi Vijayan, on Thursday, said that the recent Delhi High Court verdict in the NewsClick case was a strong blow to the "political misuse of power". In a post on the social media platform X, Vijayan said that the Delhi High Court verdict was "a major setback for the BJP, which misuses central agencies to suppress political dissent".

"The action against NewsClick and its editor, Prabir Purkayastha, was an attempt to silence critical journalism and democratic voices. This is a victory for democratic rights and press freedom over the fascist politics of the Sangh Parivar," he said on X. Vijayan was referring to the Delhi High

Court's decision to quash cases registered by the Delhi Police and the Enforcement Directorate against news portal NewsClick and its editor-in-chief, Prabir Purkayastha, in relation to alleged violations of FDI norms.

The Marxist veteran, in a Facebook post, said that right from the beginning, there were allegations that the action against NewsClick and its editor was a "political hunt" targeting critical journalism and public protests. "The court's intervention gives considerable validity to those allegations," he said. Vijayan further said that in an era of media functioning in line with "corporate-political interests", voices that question authority are the most frequently targeted.

basis that there is no deceived victim, they said.

Whereas, officials added, the case of the ED and the EOW was that "false representations" were made to statutory authorities and banks regarding the genuineness of the investor, nature of funds, source of funds, and the commercial nature of the investment and valuation of shares.

The court failed to consider that cheating need not be confined to the private sector, they said, adding that the inducement of public authorities to act upon false representations can constitute cheating where corresponding wrongful gain/wrongful loss is alleged.

ED officials feel that at the quashing stage, the issue before the high court was whether allegations, if accepted as true, disclose an offence. Whereas the judgment is based upon whether the ED had conclusively established the allegations, and whether the allegations were ultimately provable, they said. Officials added that ED investigators had collected emails and recorded statements of various persons, including those working with Purkayastha, to establish that PPK NewsClick Studio Pvt Ltd (the company that owns NewsClick) wanted to get foreign direct investment by "avoiding" government permission. The purpose of PPK NewsClick Studio LLP was changed to digital company and different arrangements were made and investment was received from Worldwide Media Holdings LLC to achieve

Delhi HC refuses bail to ex-CFO of Reliance Power



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court has refused to grant regular bail to the former Chief Financial Officer of Reliance Power Limited in a money laundering case linked to the issuance of an alleged fake bank guarantee of Rs 68 crore. Justice Madhu Jain dismissed the bail plea by Ashok Kumar Pal on Wednesday, stating that no ground was made out to give him reprieve in the case probed by the Enforcement Directorate (ED) under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act.

Considering the allegations and the material before it, the court said it was unable to conclude that there were reasonable grounds to believe that Pal was not guilty of money laundering. The case pertains to a bank guarantee of ₹68.2 crore submitted to the Solar Energy Corporation of India Limited (SECI) on behalf of Reliance NU BESS Limited, a subsidiary of Reliance Power — an Anil Ambani group

company — which was found to be "fake".

Justice Jain said the ex-CFO's claim that he had no knowledge of the alleged forgery and acted only in his official capacity would be considered during the trial when evidence is appreciated. Pal also argued that his complaint led to the registration of the predicate offence FIR, and that no proceeds of crime accrued to him.

"Having regard to the nature of the allegations and the material relied upon by the Directorate of Enforcement, including statements recorded under Section 50 of the PMLA, documentary material and electronic communications collected during investigation, this court is unable to record satisfaction that there are reasonable grounds for believing that the applicant is not guilty of the offence alleged," the court concluded. "The twin conditions prescribed under Section 45 of the PMLA (for granting bail) are, therefore, not satisfied at this stage. In view of the above, the applicant is not entitled to regular bail," it ordered.

Bombay HC sets aside education dept orders, Vidarbha schools to reopen after June 30

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Nagpur

The Bombay High Court has set aside two orders issued by the Maharashtra education department concerning the reopening of schools in the State's Vidarbha region and directed that schools there reopen after June 30.

The directive by the high court's Nagpur bench came on Wednesday on a petition filed by Vijay D Kombe, who had challenged a governmental circular dated March 28, 2026, directing that all schools across the State reopen from June 15.

The petitioner, through his lawyer BG Kulkarni, submitted in the court that the reopening date was subsequently shifted to June 22, after he moved the HC, through another circular dated June 9 issued by the Director of Education.

According to the Kombe,



the orders violated a 2007 court directive that had held that uniform school reopening was arbitrary for Vidarbha. He also pointed to a Government Resolution (GR) of 2023 that had fixed the school reopening date as June 30. The education department justified its decision to

reopen schools on June 22 instead of June 15, saying the move addressed the petitioner's grievance and took into account the extreme heat in the Vidarbha region.

The division bench of Justices Anil Kilor and Raj Wakode said that the education department's orders con-

flicted with the directions issued by a Coordinate Bench of the HC on June 8, 2007, in a petition filed against the reopening of schools in Maharashtra from June 15.

Taking into consideration the high temperatures in the Vidarbha region and their possible adverse impact on the health of students, the Coordinate Bench had held that in 2007 held that such a decision (reopening from June 15) in respect of the Vidarbha region was unreasonable. Since the Coordinate Bench had dealt with the issue, the HC said, the education department should not have issued the circulars.

The HC quashed the impugned circulars dated March 28, 2026, and June 9, 2026, and directed the Government to act in accordance with the GR of 2023 and ensure that schools in the Vidarbha region reopen after June 30.

Psychological evaluation of children shouldn't be ordered routinely: SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In a significant verdict, the Supreme Court held on Thursday that children cannot be treated as "mere evidentiary objects" and that psychological or psychiatric evaluation should not be ordered routinely to satisfy the competing claims of estranged parents involved in bitter custody-and-visitation disputes.

A bench of Justices Sanjay Karol and Nongmeikapam Kotiswar Singh issued a slew

of directions for dealing with cases involving a psychological or psychiatric evaluation of minor children in proceedings arising out of custody, visitation or parental-access disputes.

The directions were issued by the bench in a verdict that modified a Bombay High Court order and set aside key directions that had allowed a four-member panel of psychologists and experts to evaluate a girl whose father is facing allegations under the Protection of Children from Sexual

Offences (POCSO) Act. Justice Singh, who authored the 65-page verdict, quoted Nelson Mandela, who had said, "There can be no keener revelation of a society's soul than the way in which it treats its children."

"In all proceedings, more particularly, involving a minor child alleged to be a victim under the POCSO Act, the paramount consideration shall always remain the welfare, emotional security, dignity and psychological wellbeing of the child," the court said. In one of the direc-



tions, the bench said a psychological evaluation of a child victim shall not be directed as a matter of routine merely because issues of custody, visitation or parental access have arisen between the litigating parents or relatives.

"Before directing any such evaluative process concerning the child, the court shall record specific reasons demonstrating the necessity of such evaluation, the purpose sought to be achieved, the relevance of the proposed exercise and the

reasons why less-intrusive alternatives would not sufficiently subserve the interests of the child," it said.

The verdict said courts must adopt the "principle of minimum intrusion and minimum exposure" while directing a psychological interaction with child victims.

"Repeated, overlapping or multi-layered psychological evaluations of a child victim should ordinarily be avoided unless compelling circumstances exist and reasons are specifically recorded in writing," it said.

The verdict said where a psychological evaluation is considered necessary, ordinarily, the same should be conducted by an independent and court-appointed child psychologist or psychiatrist. "The constitution of a panel of experts should remain an exceptional course, to be adopted only where the court is satisfied that the peculiar facts of the case render such a course indispensable," it said, adding that the experts must be independent and neutral.

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SBI, ICICI, other banks hike FCNR deposit rates



Several banks, including ICICI and SBI, on Thursday launched a new Foreign Currency Non-Resident (FCNR (B)) deposit scheme offering higher interest rates for Non-Resident Indians. The NRI fixed deposit interest rate hikes came within days of the RBI announcing a foreign currency swap window for banks till September 30, thus effectively absorbing the currency hedging cost that banks had to bear on such deposits and leaving room for banks to raise deposit rates. The move is aimed at attracting foreign currency deposits from Non-Resident Indians (NRIs), and experts believe that about USD 60-70 billion foreign capital could flow in under the deposit scheme. Following this, ICICI Bank, on its website, said it is offering 6.50 per cent interest on NRI fixed deposits effective June 11. State Bank of India (SBI) announced a new SBI Advantage FCNR(B) deposit scheme available in USD for a 3-5 year tenure with a lock-in period of 1 year. Deposits above USD 1 million for 3-4 years will attract 5.5 per cent interest, while 4-5 years (5.75 per cent interest), and those with 5 years tenure will attract 6 per cent interest. Bank of Baroda (BoB) said it is offering higher interest rates for deposits in the 3-to-5-year maturity bucket across major foreign currencies, including the US Dollar (USD), British Pound Sterling (GBP), Euro, Australian Dollar (AUD) and Canadian Dollar (CAD) under the new FCNR (B) Deposit Scheme. Customers would earn up to 6 per cent on USD deposits, 4.75 per cent on GBP and AUD deposits, 5.15 per cent on CAD deposits and 3.75 per cent on Euro deposits with effect from June 11. Kotak Mahindra Bank on its website said that FCNR (B) deposit interest rates, with effect from June 11, will be 6 per cent for 3-5 year deposits less than USD 1 million, and 6.15 per cent for deposits more than USD 1 million. (PTI)

Bajaj Auto Foundation commits ₹400cr to empower women engineers



Bajaj Auto's CSR arm Bajaj Auto Foundation on Thursday announced it is committing ₹400 crore over the next decade to empower women engineers, and unveiled its unified vision towards skilling and empowerment. The initiative will be implemented through the Rupa Rahul Bajaj Scholarship for Women in Engineering (RRBSWE), it said. The announcement was made at an event held at the company's headquarters in Pune in the presence of Kiran Mazumdar-Shaw, Chairperson and Founder of Biocon Limited, and Rajiv Bajaj, Managing Director of Bajaj Auto Ltd. It also formally unveiled the scholarship identity and felicitated the inaugural cohort of 506 meritorious young scholars from 40 reputed engineering institutions, considered to be the country's largest scholarship programme for women in core engineering. The scholarship has been conceived for meritorious young women pursuing core engineering disciplines, including mechanical, electronics, industrial instrumentation, mechatronics, robotics engineering and allied fields. Under the programme, scholars will receive financial support of up to ₹8 lakh across the course of their engineering education at 40 leading engineering institutions, including IITs, NITs, IIITs, and reputed state and private universities, the foundation said. The event also saw the unveiling of Bajaj Auto Foundation's unified vision towards skilling and empowerment. "Women possess inherent skills of patience, empathy and diligence, which are very strong attributes to excel in core engineering jobs. We identified this long back and made women engineers a significant part of our workforce. In fact, from virtually no women in our operations till around a decade back, today they account for nearly 20 per cent of our workforce," said Rajiv Bajaj. (PTI)

Haleon to invest ₹2,000 cr to set up its manufacturing facility in India

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Haleon, a consumer company that is solely focused on better everyday health, today announced plans to establish its first manufacturing facility in India; a state-of-the-art greenfield site at Pithampur, Madhya Pradesh. Spread across more than 40 acres in the Smart Industrial Park, the facility marks a significant investment in India's consumer health sector and reinforces Haleon's long-term commitment to the country as a strategic growth market. The announcement was made in the presence of Dr Mohan Yadav, Chief Minister of

Madhya Pradesh; Brian McNamara, Chief Executive Officer, Haleon; Kedar Lele, CEO India and President India Subcontinent, Haleon and Namrata Patel, Chief Supply Chain Officer, Haleon. The new manufacturing site will serve as a key enabler for Haleon's growth in India, strengthening supply chain resilience, driving domestic value addition, and supporting export to wider Asia. Aligned with the Government's 'Make in India' vision, the investment is expected to generate broad-based economic value over the next decade, enhancing export competitiveness, contributing to state revenues,



India's economic growth rate to weaken at 6.6% in FY27: BMI

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India's GDP is likely to grow at 6.6 per cent in the current fiscal as compared to 7.7 per cent in FY26, on weaker investments and consumption growth and trade shocks from the West Asia crisis, BMI, a Fitch group company, said. According to government data released last week, GDP growth in FY26 accelerated to 7.7 per cent from 7.1 per cent in FY25, supported by healthy consumption and robust investment activity. BMI expects the rupee to trade in the range of 95.1 against the US dollar this calendar year. It said the rupee's depreciation from its 87 average level in 2025 will support export competitive-



ness, offsetting the drag on GDP from the Iran conflict's terms-of-trade shock. The GST reforms implemented in September 2025 caused a consumption boom in December quarter FY26. Thereafter, consumption growth fell by 1.1 percentage points to 7.1 per cent y-o-y in March quarter FY26. "Looking ahead, we continue to expect

6.6 per cent GDP growth in FY2026/27. Our projection represents a visible slowdown from FY2025-26's 7.7 per cent pace but exceeds India's average 6.1 per cent per annum growth rate over the last decade," it said. BMI's projection is in line with RBI's 6.6 per cent growth estimates for FY27. BMI attributed the slow growth rate this

fiscal to three factors. First, the impact of last year's GST reforms on domestic consumption is likely to wane. Also, higher price inflation which BMI expects to hit 5.3 per cent in FY27 will hinder consumption growth amid disruption at Strait of Hormuz. Thirdly, BMI expects investment growth to slow during the fiscal year. "This slowdown is not due to our new forecast of accumulative 50 basis points (bps) rate hike by the RBI in FY2026/27, since the effect on growth will primarily be felt during FY2027/28," BMI said the currently low level of short-term interest rates following the RBI's 125 bps rate cut during 2025 will support the economy through the ongoing energy crisis.

'Modi Govt's 12 years are transformational for industry'

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Maruti Suzuki India Chairman R C Bhargava on Thursday hailed the Narendra Modi-led government's economic and industrial policies, a day after he became the country's longest continuously serving elected prime minister. In a post on X, Bhargava said the past 12 years have been "transformational for industry", and have created more opportunities for Indian companies to access global markets and expand bilateral trade. Pointing to developments in the automobile sector, Bhargava noted that Maruti Suzuki's annual vehicle exports had increased from about 1,00,000 units in 2013-14 to around 4,50,000 units in 2025-26. He also said India has emerged as the world's third-largest car manufactur-



ing nation. "The close link between industrial growth, competitiveness and the growth of employment and wealth in the country was first recognised, and measures taken to remove past obstacles, after Mr. Modi became the Prime Minister in 2014," Bhargava said. The Maruti Suzuki India chairman linked the government initiatives targeting rural development and prosperity to the rise in the share of cars sold by the company in rural

areas. "The share of MSIL cars sold in rural areas increased from 32 per cent to 52 per cent, a truly remarkable transformation resulting from government policies," he shared. Bhargava observed that under the Narendra Modi-led government, the infrastructure programme was sharply intensified and helped reduce logistic costs. "India is increasingly becoming a preferred destination for supply chains moving out of China," he stated. The Maruti Suzuki India

chairman said a series of reforms undertaken since 2014 had improved India's competitiveness, reduced costs for businesses and strengthened the country's position in global manufacturing and supply chains. "The result has been more opportunities for Indian industry to access foreign markets and increase bilateral trade. Truly, these 12 years have been transformational for industry, and we look with great confidence to the future, under his leadership," Bhargava said. The Maruti Suzuki chairman said the government recognised the link between industrial growth, employment generation and wealth creation, and took steps to improve the ease of doing business, remove legal impediments to growth, reform the tax structure and accelerate the adoption of digital technology.

Crude oil slips nearly 2% in futures trade on profit-booking

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Crude oil prices declined nearly 2 per cent to ₹8,575 per barrel in futures trade on Thursday as traders booked profits after the recent rally, tracking a weak trend in the global markets. On the Multi Commodity Exchange (MCX), crude oil contracts for June delivery fell by ₹151, or 1.73 per cent, to ₹8,575 per barrel in a business turnover of 8,887 lots. Similarly, the July contract declined by ₹145, or 1.69 per cent, to ₹8,442 per barrel in



2,900 lots. Market participants said both contracts opened on a firm note but later slipped into the negative territory as investors locked in gains after the recent surge in prices. Analysts said the

correction in domestic futures mirrored the weakness in overseas markets, though concerns over global energy supplies continued to keep traders cautious. In the international markets, Brent crude futures for August delivery declined 0.58 per cent to USD 92.56 per barrel, while West Texas Intermediate (WTI) slipped 0.4 per cent to USD 89.67 per barrel on the NYMEX. Despite the decline, crude oil prices remained elevated amid lingering geopolitical tensions and uncertainty over supply from the Gulf region.

Oil India, Canada's PTRC sign clean energy collaboration pact

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Oil India Ltd (OIL) and Canada's Petroleum Technology Research Centre (PTRC) have signed a collaboration framework to jointly explore carbon capture, geothermal energy and other clean energy technologies, the companies said. The agreement aims to deepen energy cooperation between India and Canada as both countries pursue energy transition and sustainability goals. The framework was signed on June 10 in Calgary between PTRC, a



Saskatchewan-based not-for-profit energy research organisation, and OIL, a Maharatna public sector enterprise under India's Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas,

the Indian firm said in a statement. The collaboration will focus on carbon capture, utilisation and storage (CCUS), geothermal energy, subsurface energy technologies,

and innovation-led research, including engagement with mc2+, India's startup platform backed by the petroleum ministry. Areas of cooperation include utilisation and permanent storage of captured carbon dioxide through geological sequestration and mineralisation, development of enhanced oil recovery technologies aimed at reducing the environmental footprint of oil and gas production, and identification of business opportunities in both countries through industry partnerships and research networks.

Gold extends losses in futures trade amid inflation, West Asia crisis



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Extending losses for the fifth consecutive session, gold prices fell ₹277 to ₹1.47 lakh per 10 grams in futures trade on Thursday, tracking losses in the international markets as investors grappled with persistent geopolitical tensions in West Asia and its impact on inflation and interest rates. On the Multi Commodity Exchange, the yellow metal for August delivery decreased by ₹277, or 0.19 per cent, to ₹1,47,740 per 10 grams.

Analysts said precious metals remained under pressure as elevated energy prices and higher US economic data reignited expectations that interest rates could stay higher for longer. "Gold prices slipped in the domestic markets on Thursday amid escalating tensions between the US and Iran, which have fuelled uncertainty in the markets," Gaurav Garg, Research Analyst at Lemonn Markets Desk, said. In global markets, Comex gold futures for August contract slipped for the fifth consecutive session, falling by USD 17.23, or 0.42 per cent, to USD 4,116.07 per ounce in New York. "Gold continues its fall towards USD 4,000 per ounce even though the US

military's confirmation that its latest strikes on Iran had concluded, fuelling hope that peace talks might restart and easing some inflation worries," Renisha Chainani, Head of Research at Augmont, said. She, however, noted that the prolonged conflict and the near-complete shutdown of the Strait of Hormuz continued to disrupt energy supplies from the Persian Gulf, stoking fears of renewed inflation and possible central bank rate increases.

On Wednesday, President Donald Trump stated that Iran had delayed negotiations for too long and would now "have to pay the price". In response to US strikes on Iranian sites near the Strait of Hormuz, Iran retaliated with missile and drone attacks on American bases in Jordan, Kuwait, and Bahrain. According to Chainani, US inflation rose in May to its highest level in over three years, driven by sharp increases in energy prices, and fresh comments from President Trump have kept market sentiment cautious. Market participants are closely tracking developments in West Asia and upcoming macroeconomic indicators for fresh cues on the US Federal Reserve's policy path and the near-term direction of bullion prices.

Fertiliser subsidy estimate to be reassessed with fall in urea import prices: Government

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

The government on Thursday asserted that the fertilisers stocks in the country is comfortable to meet the demand for the ongoing kharif season and said the subsidy estimates for the current fiscal could be reassessed considering the softening of urea prices in the global markets. At an inter-ministerial briefing on recent developments in West Asia, Aparna S Sharma, additional secretary in the Union Ministry of Chemicals and Fertilisers,



said, "The stock position of fertilisers in the country is comfortable. India's fertilizer security remains as strong as ever." Asked whether the ₹3.4 lakh crore fertiliser subsidy estimates for 2026-27 would be revised downward

due to a fall in global prices, she said the preliminary subsidy estimate was based on the presumption that the trend remains the same. "But, as a result of the recent tender that has been done on behalf of the government by our one of our entities will definitely have cause to reassess the subsidy figures, and we will have a re-look on that," Sharma said. However, the additional secretary said that the reassessment would depend on the confirmation of the quantities offered by the suppliers and also the total imports.

Revenue of auto ancillary firms grew at 11% CAGR



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The revenue of listed auto ancillary companies grew at a compound annual growth rate (CAGR) of 11 per cent during FY16-26, according to a report by Equirius Securities. Sectoral revenues during the period rose nearly three-fold to about ₹5 lakh crore during the period, according to the report. It noted that exports have more than tripled over the past decade and have emerged as an important contributor to industry growth alongside rising vehicle content and premiumisation trends. The sector entered FY27 with its strongest balance sheet position in a decade, it said, adding net debt-to-EBITDA improved to 0.18 times in FY26 from 0.49 times in FY22, aided by stronger cash flows, lower leverage and better working capital management.

The report, titled "Ten Years of Growth, Three Lessons and Where to Look Next", which was released recently, analyses the performance of 52 listed auto ancillary companies and outlines key themes expected to shape the sector's growth trajectory over FY27-30. According to the report, 28 of the 52 companies under its coverage outperformed the sector's average revenue growth, while the performance varied widely across companies and segments despite the sector's overall growth. The Equirius report also said these companies are expected to deliver a CAGR of 21 per cent in profit after tax (PAT) during FY26-28. Among segments, body and glass was identified as one of the most attractive opportunities, with an estimated 30 per cent PAT CAGR over the period, it said. The report identified diversification as one of the most important drivers of long-term growth.

FROM THE WORLD

NEPAL

FM Khanal to travel to China

Nepal's Foreign Minister Shisir Khanal is likely to travel to China on Sunday with the aim of further strengthening friendly relations between the two countries. According to Foreign Ministry sources, during the visit from June 14-17, Khanal is expected to meet Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi and the chief of the International Department of the Communist Party of China, Liu Haixing. (PTI)

KUWAIT

Airspace closed over attacks

Kuwait on Thursday said it closed its airspace over ongoing Iranian attacks. Kuwait's Directorate General of Civil Aviation made the announcement. It said flights were being diverted to other airports, without elaborating. Flights circled outside of Kuwait for some time before the announcement, after the military announced its air defences were firing. "This measure comes in light of the state of Kuwait being subjected to sinful Iranian aggressions and the potential risks that may result from this on civil aviation traffic in the region," Kuwait said.(AP)

Jaishankar meets Finnish FM

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Helsinki

External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar on Thursday held talks with his Finnish counterpart Elina Valtonen on India-Finland strategic partnership and discussed cooperation across a range of emerging technology sectors. "Agreed to deepen trade & investment, while maintaining the momentum of our political engagement," Jaishankar posted on social media.

The two ministers discussed collaboration on startups, artificial intelligence, semiconductors, critical minerals, quantum technologies, 6G, clean energy and space, according to the post. "Finland and India have excellent bilateral relations," Valtonen reiterated in a social media post after



External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar with Finland Foreign Affairs Minister Elina Valtonen during a meeting, in Helsinki PTI

meeting Jaishankar. "We will continue deepening our trade ties and see significant potential in digitalisation and sustainability."

The meeting comes months after India and Finland elevated their bilateral relationship to a strategic partnership in digitalisation and sustainability during Finnish President Alexander Stubb's visit to India earlier this year.

During that visit, PM Narendra Modi and Stubb had announced the partnership, with Modi noting that relations between India and Europe were entering a "golden era," a sentiment which was further reinforced by the conclusion of the India-EU Free Trade Agreement in January. The deal, concluded after nearly two decades of negotiations, covers a market of two billion people and roughly a quarter of the global GDP.

Following the bilateral meeting, Jaishankar is scheduled to attend the 14th edition of the Kultaranta Talks, themed "A World in Transition: Global, Regional and Local Perspectives", and engage with Finnish leadership and other participants. The annual dialogue, hosted by the Finnish president, brings together senior leaders and policymakers to discuss global and regional security challenges.

Meanwhile, Jaishankar has pushed for "dialogue and diplomacy" as the only solution amid ongoing multiple conflicts and reiterated India's stance that this is "not an era of war."

Jaishankar made these remarks on Wednesday after the meeting with his Bulgarian counterpart Velislava Petrova-Chamova.



Drone strikes by Sudanese forces kill 15 people

FATMA KHALED/YASSIR ABDALLA ■ Cairo

Sudanese paramilitary forces carried out drone strikes overnight in central Sudan, killing at least 15 people and wounding dozens, health officials said Thursday, as the use of unmanned aircraft becomes increasingly common in the more than three-year war in the African country.

The attacks, which started late Wednesday, targeted various areas of the city of el-Obeid, including near an army position, according to two health officials at el-Obeid Hospital, which received the victims. More than 10 people were also wounded, some critically, the officials said, speaking on condition of anonymity because they were not authorised to speak to the media.

The war in Sudan erupted in April 2023, after long-simmering tensions between the army and paramilitary Rapid Support Forces, or RSF. The conflict has killed at least 59,000 people, displaced some 13 million, and pushed many parts of the country into famine. More

than 30 million people need humanitarian assistance.

Dr Mohamed Elsheikh, a spokesperson with Sudan Doctors Network, which tracks casualty tolls, told The Associated Press that in el-Obeid, RSF drones also hit a funeral gathering at a cemetery, killing four people there, and a gas station. He could not immediately confirm if the casualties were civilians, combatants or both.

An aid worker with Mercy Corps told the AP that drone attacks have intensified across el-Obeid in recent days, targeting gatherings of people in the city. The worker, who spoke on condition of anonymity for fear of reprisals, said schools have suspended classes and markets are only partially open because of the attacks.

Emergency Lawyers, a local aid monitoring group, said Thursday the toll is likely to increase as drones were still flying over the city.

The group said homes near the military headquarters of the 5th Infantry Division in el-Obeid were hit, as well as a truck carrying food supplies into the city. Its driver was killed, the group said. (AP)



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Central Bank of India

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E-AUCTION SALE NOTICE

(Under SARFAESI Act 2002)

APPENDIX- IV-A [SEE PROVISIO TO RULE 8(6) & 9(1)] SALE NOTICE FOR SALE OF IMMOVABLE PROPERTIES

E-Auction Sale Notice for sale of Immovable Assets under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8(6) & 9(1) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002.

Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the borrower(s) and guarantor(s) that the below described immovable property mortgaged / charged to the Central Bank of India (secured creditor), the constructive/ physical Possession of which have been taken by the authorized officer of Central Bank of India (Secured creditors), will be sold on "As is where is", "As is what is" and "whatever there is" basis on date 29.06.2026 for recovery of dues to the Central Bank of India from below mention Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s). The Reserve Price and Earnest money deposit (EMD) is displayed against the details of respective properties.

E-AUCTION SCHEDULED TO BE HELD ON 29.06.2026 (15 DAY'S NOTICE)							In Rupees
S. No.	Name of Branch	Authorised Officer/ Branch Head	Name of the Account	Description of Property & Owner Name	Demand Notice Date & Amount Dues (In Rupees)	Date & Type of Possession	Reserve Price EMD Bid Increase
1.	Anand Parbat New Delhi	Mr. Mukesh Rathore MOBILE: 9211521403	Mr. Pramod Gupta & Mrs. Chander Wati	Property Bearing No.RZ-6K/11/563 (Old No.RZ-6K/11) Out of Khasra No.650, Entire Third Floor with Terrace Rights, Indira Park, Palam Colony, Nasirpur, New Delhi-110045. Area Measuring 75 Sq.Yds. Owner - Mr. Pramod Gupta	Rs.46,86,662.00 on 05.07.2022 + interest thereafter	06.04.2024 (Physical)	₹ 22,50,000.00 ₹ 2,25,000.00 ₹ 20,000.00
2.	Gulmohar Park New Delhi	Ms. Archana Sharma Mobile: 8448296394	Vipin Kumar Gaur	First Floor Back Side Left Side Portion without Roof Rights, part of Property No RZ-902, Gali No- 23, measuring Area 45.84 Sq Mtr, out of Khasra No 445, Situated at Tuglakabad Extension, New Delhi- 110019, Owner- Mr. Vipin Kumar Gaur S/o Mr. Murari Lal	Rs. 32,83,616.60 on 14.05.2025 + Interest thereafter	26.12.2025 (Physical)	₹ 19,00,000.00 ₹ 1,90,000.00 ₹ 20,000.00
3.	Janpath New Delhi	Mr. Ravi Kumar Mobile: 9999917105	Mr. Mahindra Kumar, Mr.Lalit Kumar & Mrs. Seema	Plot No.E-649 (Old No.13), Out of Khasara No.30/21, Mauza Saran, Dabua Colony, Faridabad, Measuring land area of 250 sq.yard. Owner- Mr. Lalit Kumar & Mr. Mahinder Kumar	Rs.30,23,089.00 on 29.10.2016 + interest thereafter	11.05.2017 (Physical)	₹ 36,34,000.00 ₹ 3,63,400.00 ₹ 35,000.00
4.	Janpath New Delhi	Mr. Ravi Kumar Mobile: 9999917105	Mr. Rakesh Kumar & Mrs. Anita Devi	LIG Flat No. G-3 (Without Roof Rights), Ground Floor, Plot No. 222, Shalimar Garden Extension 1, Vill.- Pasonda, Ghaziabad, UP-201005, Owner- Mr. Rakesh Kumar & Mrs. Anita Devi	Rs.17,09,512.00 on 06.01.2017 + interest thereafter	07.12.2021 (Physical)	₹ 14,40,000.00 ₹ 1,44,000.00 ₹ 15,000.00
5.	Karol Bagh New Delhi	Mr. Vinay Kumar Mobile: 9999917126	Mr. Ranjeet Singh	DDA built up Residential Flat No. 20 Fourth Floor (LIG) in Pocket- 3, Block- F-8, Sector- G-8, Narela, Delhi- 110040, Area- 472 Sq Ft, Owner- Mr. Ranjeet Singh S/o Mr. Amrik Singh	Rs. 14,20,145.46 on 30.05.2023 + interest thereafter	30.07.2025 (Physical)	₹ 11,92,000.00 ₹ 1,19,200.00 ₹ 10,000.00
6.	Lady Harding Medical College	Ms. Kumari Ritu Mobile: 9319992541	Mr. Imran Khan and Mrs. Rehana	Free hold Residential Flat No.- F.F.- 1 First Floor (HIG) without Roof Rights on Plot No B-1/16, DLF AnkurVihar, Loni, Ghaziabad, Area-900 Sq Ft, Owner- Mr. Imran Khan S/o Mr. Mohammed Sharif and Mrs. Rehana W/o Mr. Imran Khan	Rs.10,01,634.29 on 14.06.2024 + interest thereafter	29.05.2025 (Physical)	₹ 15,30,000.00 ₹ 1,53,000.00 ₹ 15,000.00
7.	Paharganj New Delhi	Mr. Rajiv Kumar Mobile: 8847236384	Mr. Rakesh Kumar Sahu	Residential LIG Flat No SF- 3 (Second Floor), back Side with Roof Rights, situated at Plot No M.M.- 43, DLF Ankur Vihar, Village- Loni, District- Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh - 201102, Super covered Area 400 Sq Feet, Owner- Mr. Rakesh Kumar Sahu S/o Mr. Laxman Prasad Sahu	Rs. 10,36,988.55 on 04.06.2024 + interest thereafter	19.12.2025 (Physical)	₹ 9,15,000.00 ₹ 91,500.00 ₹ 10,000.00
8.	Patel Nagar New Delhi	Mr. Sandeep Singh Mobile: 7250493569	Mr. Nitin Bhatia	Second Floor without Roof/ Terrace Rights of Built Up Property Bearing No. 191, Area measuring 50 Sq Yards, Part of Khasra No. 171 situated in the Area of Village Bindarpur, Colony known as Nand Ram Park, Block-A, Uttam Nagar, New Delhi- 110059, Owner- Mr. Nitin Bhatia S/o Mr. Khem Chand Bhatia	Rs. 12,88,716.00 on 26.08.2024 + interest thereafter	30.05.2025 (Physical)	₹ 18,00,000.00 ₹ 1,80,000.00 ₹ 20,000.00
9.	Okhla New Delhi	Mr. Praveen Kumar Mobile: 9205596548	Mr. Narayan Bhattacharjee	Second Floor Pvt Bearing No SF-4, without it's Roof Rights, Portion of Property No.- H-1/55, Area Measuring 60 Square Yards i.e. 50.166 Sq Meter, Out of Khasra No 79/17/20 and 79/24, Situated in the Area of Village- Palam, Colony known as Mahavir Enclave, New Delhi- 110045, with one small Car Parking stilt Ground Floor, Owner- Mr. Narayan Bhattacharjee and Mrs. Jhumi Bhattacharjee.	Rs. 41,70,305.00 on 30.11.2024 + Interest thereafter	12.12.2025 (Physical)	₹ 27,00,000.00 ₹ 2,70,000.00 ₹ 30,000.00

E-AUCTION DATE: 29.06.2026, TIME: 12:00 NOON TO 04:00 PM WITH AUTO EXTENSION OF 10 MINUTES

Last Date & Time of Submission of EMD and Documents (Online) On or Before: 29.06.2026 Upto 03:30 PM.

Bidder will register on website: <https://BAANKNET.com> and upload KYC documents and after verification of KYC documents by the service provider, EMD to be deposited in BAANKNET EMD wallet through NEFT/RTGS/Transfer / Generation of challan from (<https://BAANKNET.com>). The auction will be conducted through common landing platform BAANKNET.com Portal (<https://BAANKNET.com>). E-auction will be held "As is where is", "As is what is" and "whatever there is" basis. Property shall be sold only above the Reserve Price. (All other charges/dues to the property will be borne by the purchaser). For detailed terms and conditions please refer to the link provided in www.centralbank.bank.in Secured Creditor or auction platform (<https://BAANKNET.com>). Helpdesk: (+91) 8291220220, E-mail: support.BAANKNET@psballiance.com

STATUTORY 15 DAY'S SALE NOTICE UNDER RULE 8(6) & 9(1) OF THE SARFAESI ACT, 2002

Borrowers/Guarantors/ Mortgagees are hereby notified to pay the sum as mentioned above along with upto date interest and ancillary expenses before the date of e-auction, failing which the property will be auctioned/sold and balance dues, if any, will be recovered with interest and cost.

DATE: 11.06.2026
PLACE: NEW DELHI

Authorised Officer,
CENTRAL BANK OF INDIA, RO Delhi (South), New Delhi



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Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the borrower(s) and guarantor(s) that the below described immovable property mortgaged / charged to the secured creditor, the Physical / Symbolic Possession of which have been taken by the Authorized officer of Central Bank of India, secured creditors, will be sold on 29.06.2026 "As is where is", "As is what is" and "whatever there is" basis for recovery of dues to the Central Bank of India from below mention Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s). The Reserve Price and earnest money deposit (EMD) is displayed against the details of respective properties. For detailed terms and conditions of the sale, please refer to the link provided in: www.centralbank.bank.in or (<https://BAANKNET.com>)

DESCRIPTION OF PROPERTIES TO BE AUCTIONED ON 29.06.2026 (15 DAYS NOTICE)

S. No.	Name of Branch	Authorised Officer/ B.M.	Name of the Account	Description of Property & Owner Name	Demand Notice Date & Amount Dues (Rs. in Lakhs)	Date & Type of Possession	Reserve Price EMD Bid Increase
1.	Naraina New Delhi	Mr. Peeyush Pushpam MOBILE: 8800013528	Satish Kumar Singh and Poonam Singh	Residential Property bearing No. B-1/5 and 6, First Floor Back Side Portion, Without Roof/ Terrace Rights, Area measuring 50 Sq Yards, Situated in the area of Village- Palam, Colony known as Rajapuri, Gali No.- 5, Uttam Nagar, New Delhi- 110059, Owner- Mrs. Poonam Singh W/o Mr. Satish Kumar Singh S/o Mr. Tej Bahadur Singh	Rs. 11,26,590.45 on 18.12.2025 + interest thereafter	28.06.2025 (Physical)	₹ 14,40,000.00 ₹ 1,44,000.00 ₹ 15,000.00
2.	Delhi Cantonment New Delhi	Miss Nishat Fatima MOBILE: 8178791119	Rajesh Tiwari and Rakesh Tiwari	Flat No- E- 100 (Old No- WZ 346), Flat on Third Floor Without Roof/Terrace Rights, Area measuring 80 Sq Yards, out of Khasra No. 95/22, situated in the area of Village- Palam, Delhi State, Gali No. 17-B, Colony known as Sadh Nagar, New Delhi- 110045, Owner- Mr. Rajesh Tiwari and Mr. Rakesh Tiwari	Rs.25,07,504.42 as on 15.05.2024 + Interest + Other Charges	11.02.2025 (Physical Possession)	₹ 20,70,000.00 ₹ 2,07,000.00 ₹ 20,000.00
3.	Old Rajapuri New Delhi	Ms. Nishat Fatima MOB: 8800013552	MR. MOHAN KUMAR GHOSHAL & MRS. SONALI GHOSHAL	Residential Property Bearing No.23, Third Floor, with Roof / Terrace Rights, built on land area measuring 60 Sq.Yds. or 50.16 Sq.Mtr. with Super Area 540 Sq.Ft. out of Khasra No.64/4, situated in the area of Village Hastals Now the Residential Colony is known as Mohan Garden Block-K-1 Extension Near Kamal School & ICICI Bank, Uttam Nagar, New Delhi-110059.	Rs.11,41,846.38 on 01.05.2025 + Interest + Other Charges	08.04.2025 (Physical)	₹ 18,00,000.00 ₹ 1,80,000.00 ₹ 20,000.00
4.	Jonapur New Delhi	Mr. Bhushan Kumar MOBILE: 9617493179	Mr. Ishwar Singh	EWS Residential Flat No. F-4301-BHK, Ground Floor Nand Nikunj, NandGhrum, Ghaziabad-201003 Measuring area 19.53 SQ. MTRS in the Name of Mr.Ishwar Singh	Rs.8,00,095.00 on 05.05.2026 + Interest + Other Charges	03.12.2024 (Physical)	₹ 6,90,000.00 ₹ 69,000.00 ₹ 10,000.00
5.	Jonapur New Delhi	Mr. Bhushan Kumar MOBILE: 9617493179	Mrs. Kajal Verma & Mr. Sonu Sharma	Residential Flat at Flat No.319-A1-BHK, 1st Floor, Nyay Khand-III, Indrapuram, Ghaziabad-201014, Measuring Area 209.89 Sq.Ft.in the Name of Mr. Sonu Sharma & Mrs. Kajal Verma	Rs.11,98,020.00 on 24.07.2023 + Interest + Other Charges	03.12.2024 (Physical)	₹ 8,80,000.00 ₹ 88,000.00 ₹ 10,000.00

E-AUCTION DATE: 29.06.2026, TIME: 12:00 NOON TO 4:00 PM WITH AUTO EXTENSION OF 10 MINUTES

Last Date & Time of Submission of EMD and Documents (Online) On or Before: 29.06.2026 Upto 3:30 PM. Bidder will register on website: (<https://BAANKNET.com>) and upload KYC documents and after verification of KYC documents by the service provider, EMD to be deposited in Global EMD Wallet through NEFT/RTGS/Transfer (after generation of challan from (<https://BAANKNET.com>)). The auction will be conducted through the Bank's approved service provider "<https://BAANKNET.com>" E-auction will be held on "As is where is", "As is what is" and "whatever there is" basis. (All other charges/dues to the property will be borne by the purchaser). For detailed terms and conditions please refer to the link provided in www.centralbank.bank.in Secured Creditor or Auction Platform (<https://BAANKNET.com>) BAANKNET Helpdesk: (+91) 8291220220, E-mail: support.BAANKNET@psballiance.com

NOTICE FOR SUB STATUTORY 15 DAYS SALE NOTICE UNDER RULE 8(6) & 9(1) OF SARFAESI ACT 2002

The borrowers/guarantors/ mortgagees are hereby notified to pay the sum as mentioned above along with upto date interest and ancillary expenses before the date of e-auction, failing which the property will be auctioned/sold and balance dues, if any, will be recovered with interest and cost.

DATE: 11.06.2026
PLACE: DELHI

Authorised Officer, CENTRAL BANK OF INDIA,
Regional Office (Gurugram) Chandni Chowk, Delhi

Pope slams world’s indifference to migrants

NICOLE WINFIELD/HELENA ALVES/RENATA BRITO
■ Arguineguin (Spain)

Pope Leo XIV travelled to a once-notorious epicentre of the European migration debate on Thursday, challenging countries to uphold migrants’ rights while shaming those leaders, including Christians, who turn them away with indifference. Leo issued an impassioned plea to recognise the dignity of migrants from the port of Arguineguin, in the Canary Islands. In 2020, the port was dubbed “dock of shame” because of the squalid con-

ditions migrants were forced to live in for months during a spike in arrivals. “Human dignity has no passport and does not lose its value when crossing a border,” Leo said, with rescue ships docked behind him and a simple wooden cross made from a shipwrecked migrant boat nearby. Leo is spending the final two days of his weeklong trip to Spain in the Canary Islands, a Spanish archipelago closer to Africa than the Iberian Peninsula and a key point of entry for migrants who make the perilous Atlantic crossing from West



Priests gather around Antoni Gaudí’s Basilica of the Sagrada Família as Pope Leo XIV blesses the newly completed central Tower of Jesus Christ in Barcelona, Spain AP

Africa. He was fulfilling a wish of Pope Francis to visit the Canary Islands to commemorate the thousands of lives lost at sea. With two migrants standing by him, Leo threw a bouquet of flowers into the sea. The gesture recalled one Francis made in 2013, at the start of his pontificate, when he visited another migration flashpoint in Lampedusa, Sicily and denounced the “globalisation of indifference” that the world showed migrants. The Canary Islands have long been a stepping stone for migrants trying to reach

Europe from West Africa and Morocco. Some experts consider the Atlantic route they take to get here more deadly than the more well-known central Mediterranean smuggling route from Libya and Tunisia to Italy. Migrant arrivals in the Canary Islands peaked in 2024 at nearly 47,000. Following pressure and deals between the European Union, Spain and the governments of several West African nations, arrivals have fallen dramatically, with just over 3,000 people landing there in the first five months of 2026. (AP)

Canadian cop shot dead while probing US consulate attack



ROB GILLIES ■ Ottawa

A Toronto police officer was shot and killed Thursday by a suspect in the investigation into a shooting attack that damaged the facade of the US Consulate in the Canadian city in March, police said. One suspect was in custody at a hospital while officers searched for a second suspect, who was identified as 19-year-old Zara Jabbi and was considered armed and dangerous, Toronto Police Chief Myron Demkiw said at a news conference. “I urge you to turn yourself in,” Demkiw said. Police officer Marc Pinizotto, who was 43 and had been on the force for 18 years, died of his wounds in a hospital, Demkiw said. Canadian police had said in March that two individuals emerged from a white Honda RV SUV at around 4:30 am

and fired multiple shots at the consulate building before fleeing. The shooting damaged the outside of the building but did not cause any injuries. The consulate attack in March followed heightened tensions over the war launched by the US and Israel against Iran in late February, and it had followed gunfire attacks on two Toronto-area synagogues the previous weekend. The investigation that led to Pinizotto’s death “concerned a number of shootings, including the shooting at the United States consulate on University Avenue. There were several search warrants executed this morning,” Demkiw said. Toronto Mayor Olivia Chow said she’s known the mother of the deceased officer for the 20 years. “Their grief is shared across this city,” Chow said. (AP)

India’s missile program has wider ambitions: Pak official

SAJJAD HUSSAIN ■ Islamabad

A senior Pakistani defence official on Thursday claimed that India’s long-range missile development reflected ambitions extending beyond South Asia. Adviser to National Command Authority, Lt Gen (ret’d) Mazhar Jamil, made the comments while addressing a seminar on Pakistan’s nuclear weapon program organised by the Centre for International Strategic Studies (CISS). “The trajectory of India’s strategic forces program, including its intercontinental range missile systems, is not oriented solely toward Pakistan or China. It is oriented toward establishing India as a global nuclear power capable of threat-

ening major Western capitals,” Gen Jamil, a former director general of the Strategic Plans Division, claimed. He asked Western Governments to take notice of India’s military modernisation. Jamil also said that Pakistan’s restraint during the May conflict with India was “a deliberate and considered choice.” He warned that any future military action would draw a “decisive and comprehensive” response. In his opening remarks, CISS Executive Director Ali Sarwar Naqvi said Pakistan’s nuclear capability had helped maintain “deterrence stability” in South Asia and “prevented a large-scale war”. (PTI)

Crew evacuated after third vessel with Indians attacked off Oman

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Dubai

Crew members of a tanker carrying 20 Indians were evacuated on Thursday after the vessel, MT Marivex, was attacked off an Oman port, Indian officials said. This was the third instance of a merchant ship with Indian crew members coming under attack from the US military off the Oman coast in the last four days. A Palau-flagged oil tanker carrying 24 Indian seafarers was disabled by US forces on Monday. All crew members of the vessel, MT Marivex, were safely rescued. On Wednesday, the US struck another Palau-flagged tanker, MT Settebello, killing three out of the 24 Indian sailors on board.



Following Wednesday’s incident, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) summoned US Charge d’Affaires Jason Meeks and he was handed a diplomatic note of protest. The third attack — on a Guinea-Bissau-flagged vessel identified as MT

jalveer — took place on Thursday. The Indian Embassy in Muscat said in a post on X: “The rescue operation with the support of the Omani authorities has been successfully completed and all the 20 Indian crew members have been evacuated ashore. The

Mission is coordinating with the Omani authorities on further actions.” The mission had earlier posted that 22 Indian crew members were evacuated, and later revised the figure to 20. The MEA confirmed that the ship had come under attack. “These attacks came from the US Navy that is stationed there,” MEA spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said at a press briefing in New Delhi while responding to a question on the incidents involving the vessels. “We attach high importance to the welfare and well-being of our seafaring community,” Jaiswal said. He further said India has conveyed that “dialogue and diplomacy is the way forward for the peaceful resolution of the conflict”.

सेन्ट्रल बैंक ऑफ इंडिया Central Bank of India			Regional Office Delhi (North) 1398, First Floor, Chandni Chowk, Delhi-110006.			E-AUCTION SALE NOTICE (Under SARFAESI Act 2002)				
1911 से आपके लिए "केन्द्रित" "CENTRAL" TO YOU SINCE 1911										
APPENDIX- IV-A [SEE PROVISO TO RULE 8(6)] SALE NOTICE FOR SALE OF IMMOVABLE PROPERTIES										
E-Auction Sale Notice for Sale of Immovable Assets under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8(6) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002.										
Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the borrower(s) and guarantor(s) that the below described immovable properties mortgaged / charged to the secured creditor, the Physical / Symbolic Possession of which have been taken by the Authorized officer of Central Bank of India, secured creditor, will be sold on 29-06-2026 under "As is where is", "As is what is" and "whatever there is" basis for recovery of dues to the Central Bank of India from below mention Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s). The Reserve Price and earnest money deposit (EMD) is displayed against the details of respective properties. For detailed terms and conditions of the sale, please refer to the link provided in www.centralbankofindia.co.in or (https://BAANKNET.com)										
DESCRIPTION OF PROPERTY TO BE AUCTIONED ON 29.06.2026 (15 DAY'S NOTICE)										
S No.	Branch Name	Authorised Officer / Branch Head	Name of the Account	Description of the Property and Owner Name	Demand Notice Date	Amount Dues (Rs. In Lakh)	Date & Type of Possession	Reserve Price	EMD	Bid Increase
1	Angel's Public School	Rajesh Yadav 8349135200	Anju Devi	Prop No-1801 (Plot No.-72/74), Third Floor (With roof rights) Situated in the area of Village-Chandrawali alias Shahdara in the abadi of opp. Rehman Building West Rohtash Nagar, Ilaqa Shahdara, Dethi-110032 Owner-Anju Devi W/o Mr. Varun Jain Area - 369 Sq Ft	16-11-2024	Rs. 15.87 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable deductions/ repayments	21-07-2025 Physical	Rs. 18,00,000/-	Rs. 1,80,000/-	Rs. 20,000
2	Arthala	Naveen Kumar 9220402685	Chander Kail	Flat No SF-2, Lig, Second Floor, Back Side, Plot No. A-2/15, Dif Ankur Vihar, Loni, District Ghaziabad-Up, Owner Chander Kail Area 37.16 Sq Mtr	20-09-2021	Rs.8.9 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable deductions/ repayments	21-07-2022 Physical	Rs. 8,80,000/-	Rs. 88,000/-	Rs. 10,000
3	Bhagirath Palace	Sandeep Kumar 9999463960	Dharmendra .	Shop No. C-30, Ground Floor, Block-B, Brij Vihar, Sector-8, Ghaziabad, Owner- Dharmendra Kumar Area 12.34 Sq M	01-08-2019	Rs.7.76 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable deductions/ repayments	15-05-2025 Physical	Rs. 14,00,000/-	Rs. 1,40,000/-	Rs. 15,000
4	Daryaganj	Swati Kumari 7428926731	Amit Kumar	Flat No-301, 2nd Floor, Front Side, Mig, Deep Apartments-VI, Plot No. A-4/18, Dif Ankur Vihar, Loni, Ghaziabad, Up-201102, Owner Amit Kumar (Area 750 Sq Ft.)	10-04-2019	Rs.12.59 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable deductions/ repayments	04-06-2022 Physical	Rs. 16,60,000/-	Rs. 1,66,000/-	Rs. 15,000
5	Daryaganj	Swati Kumari 7428926731	Mohd Nafees 3A-Fit Jeans	First floor, pvt flat no 202, c-1410, central portion, without roof/terrace rights, kabir nagar, gali no 08, block-c, 33 ft. Road, babarpur, shahdara, delhi-110094, area 549 sq ft, owner mohd. Nafees & mohd. Waseem	30-07-2017	Rs. 26.11 + Rs. 3.11 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable deductions/ repayments	26-02-2018 Physical	Rs. 18,50,000/-	Rs. 1,85,000/-	Rs. 20,000
6	Ghaziabad	Bhawani Deen 9999467102	Manish Pandey	Ground Floor, Residential Builder Flat No- GF-3 (Back/ Northern Portion), Plot No.- D-9/12, DLF Ankur Vihar, Ghaziabad- 201102, Area- 58.53 Sq Mtr, Owner- Manish Pandey	30-01-2023	Rs. 7.91 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable deductions/ repayments	19-08-2023 Physical	Rs. 7,60,000/-	Rs. 76,000/-	Rs. 10,000
7	Ghonda	Arvind Kumar Srivastava 9999917130	M/S Kartkey Trading Co.	Resi dental Third Floor, With Roof Rights, Part of Property No.1/2787, Near Krishna Dairy Ram Nagar, Mandoli Road , Shahdara, Delhi-110032 Owner Umesh Rani W/o Sanjeev Kumar Dubey Area 429.70 sq ft	14.01.2022	Rs.13.75 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable deductions/ repayments	19-04-2022 Physical	Rs. 21,50,000/-	Rs. 2,15,000/-	Rs. 20,000
8	Ghonda	Arvind Kumar Srivastava 9999917130	Prem Pal Bhardwaj	All Part And Parcel of Built up property, Constructed of Whatsoever upon property No. X-16, Land Area Measuring 100 Sq Yd out of Khazra No.14/22, X Block Vill- Ghonda, Street No.2, Gujran Banger, Abadi Brahampuri, Ilaqa Shahdara Delhi Area 100 SQ YD, Owner Prem Pal Bhardwaj	30-08-2024	Rs.151.12 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable deductions/ repayments	23-04-2025 Physical	Rs. 1,42,00,000/-	Rs. 14,20,000/-	Rs. 1,00,000
9	Indrapuram	Shruti Kumari 8446432580	Bhairav Ghosh	Residential builder flat, 2nd floor, flat no. S-2, Plot No. 88, Shalimar Garden Extension-1, Ghaziabad, UP, Area- 520 Sq feet (Owner- Mr. Bhairab Ghosh)	21-10-2015	Rs.17.77 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable deductions/ repayments	09-09-2017 Physical	Rs. 13,86,000/-	Rs. 1,38,600/-	Rs. 15,000
10	Indrapuram	Shruti Kumari 8446432580	Ramesh Kumar	SF4-MIG, 2ND FLOOR FRONT SIDE WITH ROOF RIGHTS, PLOT NO. F33, SLF VED VIHAR HADBAST VILLAGE SADULLABAD PARGANA LONI DASN TESIHL AND DISTRICT GHAZIABAD, UP , AREA 65.03 SQ METRE, OWNER-RAMESH KUMAR	01-07-2021	Rs.17.25 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable deductions/ repayments	09-09-2021 Physical	Rs. 14,56,000/-	Rs. 1,45,600/-	Rs. 15,000
11	Kashmere Gate	Arvind Kumar 8318025882	Sahil .	Entire Built Up First Floor without Roof Rights of Freehold Commercial Shop bearing No. B- 183, Block- B, Area measuring 636 sq ft, situated at New Sabzi Mandi, Azadpur, Delhi- 110033, Owner- Taj Fruit Company	26-12-2023	Rs.32.92 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable deductions/ repayments	09-08-2024 Physical	Rs. 73,00,000/-	Rs. 7,30,000/-	Rs. 1,00,000
12	Lawrence Road	Amit Ranjan 8800013521	Kaveri Infratech India	Portion Of Ground Floor, Part of property No- 6281/XII (old), F-87 (New), 3 Jaipuria Building, Kolhapur Road , Kamla Nagar, Delhi 110007 Owner Rishi Kumar Gupta 774 Sq Ft	14-05-2024	Rs.82.69 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable deductions/ repayments	21-01-2025 Physical	Rs. 79,00,000/-	Rs. 7,90,000/-	Rs. 1,00,000
13	LRPG College	Ektia Sharma 8800013520	Aarti Kapoor	Flat No. 304 MIG First Floor Right Hand Back Side Without Roof Rights, Situated at plot No. B-11/15, DLF Ankur Vihar, Hadbast Village-Sadullabad, Pargana & Tehsil Loni Distt. Ghaziabad Uttar Pradesh Area-55.74 Sq Mtr Owner Aarti Kapoor W/o Nitin Kapoor	22-11-2023	Rs.22.43 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable deductions/ repayments	02-12-2025 Physical	Rs. 21,60,000/-	Rs. 2,16,000/-	Rs. 20,000
14	MMH College	Sandhya Sharma 9818885548	Mahipal Singh	Property Bearing No.35-A Entire Ground Floor Khazra No.1025, Without Roof Rights New Friends Colony, Hadbast Village Dargal, Pargana-Jalalabad, Tehsil & Distt. - Ghaziabad Uttar Pradesh Area 65 Sq Mtr Owner- Mahipal Singh S/o Kundan Singh	30-06-2017	Rs.16.52 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable deductions/ repayments	12-11-2025 Physical	Rs. 20,34,000/-	Rs. 2,03,400/-	Rs. 20,000
15	New Seelampur	Md Yunus 8800013530	Shekh Anwar Hussain	Ground Floor property No.A-19 Flat No. g-1, MIG Khazra No. 1076/52/19 Situated in area of Village- Jhilmil tahripur Residential Colony Known As Dilshad Colony Ilaqa - Shahdara Delhi Area 750 Sq FT Owner Shek Anor Hussain & Sahana Bibi	10-01-2024	Rs. 29.36 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable deductions/ repayments	28-01-2025 Physical	Rs. 32,40,000/-	Rs. 3,24,000/-	Rs. 30,000

S No.	Branch Name	Authorised Officer / Branch Head	Name of the Account	Description of the Property and Owner Name	Demand Notice Date	Amount Dues (Rs. In Lakh)	Date & Type of Possession	Reserve Price	EMD	Bid Increase
16	Patel Nagar	Vinod Meena 9694707646	Harendra Kumar	Ground Floor Without Roof Right Plot No. C-28 Khazra No. 1541 Keshav Kunj, Hadbast Gram, Rassaipur, Pargana-Dasna Thesil & Distt Ghaziabad Uttar Pradesh Owner- Mr.Harendra Kumar, Area -667.36 Sq ft	09-08-2023	Rs.15.33 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable deductions/ repayments	04-06-2025 Physical	Rs. 18,00,000/-	Rs. 1,80,000/-	Rs. 20,000
17	Patel Nagar	Vinod Meena 9694707646	Mr. ABHAY SHARMA	Flat Bearing No. G-01, Ground Floor Without Roof Rights, Plot No. 46, out of Khazra No.- 1586, Krishna Enclave, Vill- Harsaon, Tehsil and Distt. Ghaziabad Uttar Pradesh Area- 57.00 Sq Mtr Owner- Abhay Sharma	02-07-2019	Rs.14.38 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable deductions/ repayments	09-01-2026 Physical	Rs. 13,42,000/-	Rs. 1,34,200/-	Rs. 15,000
18	Patel Nagar	Vinod Meena 9694707646	Soniya --	Residential Flat No. NyayKhand-3/487, E.W.S Ground Floor Without Roof Rights, Loni Indrapuram Ghaziabad Uttar Pradesh Area-24.65 Sq Mtr Owner- Ms. Soniya W/o Vikram Singh	01-03-2025	Rs.9.67 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable deductions/ repayments	05-12-2025 Physical	Rs. 11,00,000/-	Rs. 1,10,000/-	Rs. 10,000
19	Patparganj	Mohit Kumar 9122688748	Shafali Aqua Solution	First Floor (Adjoining to Property No. 87), Without Roof Rights, Upto the extent of Ceiling Level, Part of Property Bearing No. 86 out of Khazra no.5/30, Situated in layout plan of Ram Nagar in the Area of Village Khureji Khas, Ilaqa Shahdara, Delhi - 110051 Area- 85 Sq Yard Owner- Sapna W/o Rakesh Kumar	26-10-2018	Rs.29.28 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable deductions/ repayments	12-01-2026 Physical	Rs. 40,70,000/-	Rs. 4,07,000/-	Rs. 40,000
20	Pitampura	Poonam Kumari 8383803088	Feba Sabu	First Floor No.203 Without Roof/Terrace Rights built On Property Bearing Plot No. B-63, Admeasuring 57.25 Sq Yard i.e 47.87 Sq Mtr(Out Of 229 Sq Yard) Out of Khazra No.317 Situated In The Revenue Estate of Village Bindapur Area Abadi Known as Colony Sanjay Enclave , Uttam Nagar New Delhi -110059 Owner- Smt Febu Sabu & Sh. Subin T. Area-515.27 Sq Ft.	03-02-2025	Rs.16.86 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable deductions/ repayments	27-10-2025 Physical	Rs. 21,00,000/-	Rs. 2,10,000/-	Rs. 20,000
21	Sadar Bazar	Sanny Kumar 8800013540	Amit Saini	Flat Bearing No. J-44/ SL-4 on Second Floor with Roof Rights, Area measuring 600 Sq Feet, under LIG Category situated at Dilshad Garden Extension No. 1 now known as Dilshad Colony, Village- Jhilmil Tahripur, Shahdara, Delhi- 110095. Owner- Amit Saini and Vandana Saini	17-02-2021	Rs.31.03 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable deductions/ repayments	30-12-2024 Physical	Rs. 20,40,000/-	Rs. 2,04,000/-	Rs. 20,000
22	Sadar Bazar	Sanny Kumar 8800013540	Sanjay Thakur	Property bearing no. K-4A, Third Floor without Roof Rights, Khazra No 82/23, situated in the area of Village- Palam known as Mahavir Enclave, New Delhi- 110045, Area 70 Sq Yards, Owner- Sanjay Thakur and Ranjeet Thakur	18-08-2020	Rs.14.36 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable deductions/ repayments	21-11-2024 Physical	Rs. 16,00,000/-	Rs. 1,60,000/-	Rs. 15,000
23	SDS School	Bhawesh Kumar 8521795402	Shree Agencies	Entire Ground Floor without (Roof Rights Built up on Property Bearing No.29 Khazra No.430, Situated at Village Maupur in the abadi of Bhagat Singh Gali West Babar Pur, Shahdara, Delhi - 110032 Owner- Smt. Deepa Bhardwaj W/o Shri Vikas Bhardwaj, Area-360 Sq ft	20-10-2023	Rs.58.7 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable deductions/ repayments	10-06-2025 Physical	Rs. 19,00,000/-	Rs. 1,90,000/-	Rs. 20,000
24	SDS School	Bhawesh Kumar 8521795402	Shree Agencies	Property Bearing No.1/11218-A,Second Floor (Right Side Portion), Gali No. 13 Subhash Park Shahdara Delhi 110032 Owner- Smt. Deepa Bhardwaj W/o Shri Vikas Bhardwaj, Area -405 Sq ft	20-10-2023	Rs.58.7 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable deductions/ repayments	10-06-2025 Physical	Rs. 18,00,000/-	Rs. 1,80,000/-	Rs. 20,000
25	Usmanpur	Husnain Ali 9568431985	Deepak Tiwari	Built-Up Free Hold Residential Property Bearing no. A-113, Second Floor, Pvt Flat No. SF-1, Front left Side (South West), With Roof /Terrace Rights, Situated at Colony Known as SLF Ved Vihar, Pargana Loni, Tehsil & Distt Ghaziabad , Uttar Pradesh, 201102 Owner- Sh. Deepak Tiwari S/o Shri Ganesh Tiwari, Area- 400 Sq Ft	21-05-2024	Rs.11.29 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable deductions/ repayments	19-07-2025 Physical	Rs. 11,60,000/-	Rs. 1,16,000/-	Rs. 10,000
26	Usmanpur	Husnain Ali 9568431985	Mushahid Alam	Property Bearing No. F-32 & F-33, Ground Floor, Pvt Flat No. GF-2, Without Roof/terrace Rights, Situated at Colony SLF Ved Vihar, Pargana- Loni, Tehsil and Distt. Ghaziabad Uttar Pradesh- 201102 Owner- Mushahid Alam S/o Jamshed Alam, Area - 400 Sq Ft	28-05-2024	Rs.10.45 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable deductions/ repayments	19-07-2025 Physical	Rs. 11,52,000/-	Rs. 1,15,200/-	Rs. 10,000
27	Usmanpur	Husnain Ali 9568431985	Sudha Bhaskar .	Flat No. F-5, First Floor, LIG, Back Portion Without Roof, Plot No. B-1/151, Colony Dif. Dilshad Extn., Village Brahampur Urh Bhopura, Pargana- Loni, Tehsil And Distt- Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh, Area 41.805 Sq. Mtr Owner Sudha Bhaskar	21-05-2021	Rs.12.53 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable deductions/ repayments	09-04-2025 Physical	Rs. 16,00,000/-	Rs. 1,60,000/-	Rs. 15,000
28	Vasundhara	Anand Jaiswal 8800013545	Anita Sharma	Residential Builder Flat.On Part Of Khazra No 380, Out Of Four Storey Building, Ground Floor, Without Roof Rights, Vill-Indergarhi, Paragana Dasna, Near Block-C, Govindpuram, Ghaziabad UP-201001, Area 60 Sq Mtrs, Owner Anita Sharma	29-09-2020	Rs.21.3 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable deductions/ repayments	16-11-2021 Physical	Rs. 17,30,000/-	Rs. 1,73,000/-	Rs. 20,000
29	Vasundhara	Anand Jaiswal 8800013545	Vishal Kumar Sharma	Rest. Flat, Ist Floor (Without Roof Rights), Part Of Rudra Niwas On Khazra No. 380, Indergarhi, Vill. And Paragana Dasna, Ghaziabad, Area 70 Sqm (Owner Vishal Kr Sharma And Premilata Sharma)	02-09-2020	Rs.18.78 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable deductions/ repayments	20-12-2021 Physical	Rs. 16,00,000/-	Rs. 1,60,000/-	Rs. 15,000

E-AUCTION DATE: 29.06.2026 TIME: 12:00 NOON TO 4:00 PM WITH AUTO EXTENSION OF 10 MINUTES

Last Date & Time of Submission of EMD and Documents (Online) On or Before: 29.06.2026 Upto 3:30 PM. Bidder will register on website: (<https://BAANKNET.com>) and upload KYC documents and after verification of KYC documents by the service provider, EMD to be deposited in Global EMD Wallet through NEFT/RTGS/Transfer (after generation of challan from (<https://BAANKNET.com>)).

The auction will be conducted through the Bank's approved service provider "<https://BAANKNET.com>" E-auction will be held on “As is where is”, “As is what is” and “whatever is there is” basis. (All other charges/dues to the property will be borne by the purchaser).

For detailed terms and conditions please refer to the link provided in www.centralbankofindia.co.in In Secured Creditor or Auction Platform (<https://BAANKNET.com>) Helpdesk: (+91) 8291220220, E-mail: support.BAANKNET@psballiance.com

NOTICE FOR STATUTORY 15 DAYS SALE NOTICE UNDER RULE 8(6) OF SARFAEST ACT 2002

The borrowers/guarantors/ mortgagors are hereby notified to pay the sum as mentioned above along with upto date interest and ancillary expenses before the date of e-auction, failing which the property will be auctioned/sold and balance dues, if any, will be recovered with interest and cost.

DATE: 11.06.2026
PLACE: DELHI

Authorised Officer, CENTRAL BANK OF INDIA,
R.O. Delhi (North), Chandni Chowk, Delhi

India’s innovation challenge: How a democracy can fund the future



RISHI AGARWAL

India today stands at a critical crossroads. It is the world's most populous nation, one of the fastest-growing major economies, and home to a vast pool of engineers, scientists and entrepreneurs. Yet when measured by breakthrough technologies, globally valuable intellectual property, frontier patents, deep scientific research and world-leading technology companies, India continues to trail both China and the United States by a considerable margin.

The explanation is often reduced to a familiar statistic. India spends roughly 0.7 per cent of GDP on research and development, while China spends more than 2.5 per cent and the United States more than 3 per cent. But the problem is deeper than spending levels alone. The real difference lies in how nations organise themselves to take technological risks.

Innovation is fundamentally different from conventional investment. A road, bridge, refinery or power plant can be evaluated using established models. The outcomes are relatively predictable. Frontier research is different. Most projects fail. Many generate no commercial return for years. Some may take decades before their value becomes apparent. Yet a single breakthrough can create industries worth trillions of dollars.

The uncomfortable reality is that nations seeking technological leadership must be willing to fund failure.

This is where democratic governments face a challenge that authoritarian systems do not.

In a democracy, every rupee spent on speculative research competes with visible and immediate public needs. Citizens naturally ask whether scarce resources should fund uncertain technologies when there are roads to build, schools to improve, hospitals



to modernise and welfare commitments to fulfil. If a government-backed research project fails after consuming hundreds or thousands of crores, questions are raised in Parliament, audits are conducted, headlines are written and political accountability follows.

As a result, bureaucracies often become risk-averse. Civil servants are rarely rewarded for supporting a project that succeeds fifteen years later. They are often criticised for supporting one that fails today.

China operates under a different model. It can evaluate innovation as a portfolio. If seventy projects fail, twenty survive and ten transform industries, the overall programme is considered successful. Democratic systems often focus on individual failures rather than portfolio outcomes.

Yet India does not need to imitate China's political structure to compete with China technologically. Democracies have solved this problem before.

The United States built much of its technological leadership through institutions that were specifically designed to take risks. Agencies funded research that eventually led to the internet, GPS, semiconductors, advanced aerospace systems and biotechnology. Importantly, they accepted that many projects would fail.

India's challenge is therefore not a shortage of talent or ambition. It is a shortage of institutions designed to absorb technological risk.

The country should consider creating a multi-decade National Frontier Technology Mission capitalised initially at

21 lakh crore. Such a mission should focus on artificial intelligence, advanced materials, semiconductors, robotics, energy storage, quantum technologies, biotechnology and other strategic sectors that are likely to define economic leadership in the coming decades.

Equally important is how such a mission is governed.

Investment decisions should be kept at arm's length from routine ministerial and bureaucratic processes. Scientists, technologists, entrepreneurs, investors and industry experts should evaluate proposals through independent committees. Governments should define national priorities and provide capital, but they should not attempt to micromanage scientific decision-making.

The objective should not be to eliminate failure. The objective should be to ensure that failures occur within a disciplined portfolio designed to maximise long-term national returns.

India should also explore a new framework for sharing innovation risk.

Today, a promoter can obtain financing for a warehouse, commercial property or conventional manufacturing facility because the risks are understood and the assets can serve as collateral. Frontier technologies operate differently. A new battery chemistry, semiconductor architecture, biotechnology platform or artificial intelligence infrastructure project may require ten years of investment before producing meaningful revenue.

Banks cannot finance such risks. Insurance companies are not designed to do so. Mutual

funds require liquidity and predictable returns. Venture capital funds play a critical role but often operate within finite fund cycles and cannot shoulder every long-duration scientific risk.

The result is a financing vacuum precisely where the nation needs investment the most.

One solution may be a combination of recoverable grants and innovation insurance. Under such a system, approved research projects would receive support from the state. If successful, part of the support could be repaid through royalties, revenue-sharing or licensing income. If the project fails despite meeting agreed scientific and technical milestones, the loss would be treated as part of the national innovation portfolio.

Such a framework would encourage entrepreneurs to pursue ambitious technologies without transferring all risk to private capital.

At the same time, the state should expand funding for institutions such as ISRO, IISc, national laboratories and leading universities. Around the world, many transformative technologies originated not inside corporations but inside publicly funded laboratories and research institutions.

However, governments should recognise an important distinction. The state is often effective at funding invention but less effective at commercialisation. The government's comparative advantage lies in financing scientific uncertainty. The private sector's comparative advantage lies in scaling products,

serving customers, building markets and creating globally competitive businesses.

Rather than attempting to become a commercial operator, the state should focus on creating intellectual property and licensing it to industry wherever appropriate.

India must also address another structural issue: talent incentives.

Many of the country's brightest engineers face a simple economic reality. Commercial careers often offer significantly higher compensation than research careers. If India expects more people to devote their lives to scientific discovery, advanced engineering and frontier research, the financial rewards must become more competitive. A nation cannot aspire to technological leadership while systematically underpaying many of the individuals responsible for creating it.

Finally, innovation thrives in ecosystems rather than isolation. China's rise was not built solely on funding. It was built on clusters where universities, laboratories, suppliers, manufacturers, investors and logistics networks were located within the same regions. Such ecosystems dramatically reduce the cost and complexity of experimentation.

India should build similar deep-technology clusters around its strongest research institutions and industrial centres.

The twenty-first century will not be dominated simply by nations with large populations or low-cost labour. It will be shaped by countries that generate valuable intellectual property, create transformative technologies and build institutions capable of financing uncertainty over decades rather than quarters.

India already possesses the talent, entrepreneurial energy and capital required to compete. What remains to be built is an innovation architecture capable of supporting risk at scale. The question is no longer whether India can afford to invest aggressively in research and development. The more important question is whether it can afford not to.

Writer is a Managing Director of Hemraj Group

IndianOil showcases operational green sewage treatment plant on World Environment Day

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Marking World Environment Day 2026, IndianOil's Refineries Division highlighted a significant sustainability milestone with the successful operation of a first-of-its-kind Green Sewage Treatment Plant (STP) at its Haldia Refinery in West Bengal.

The innovative facility, powered by Integrated Wetland Technology (IWT), has been operational since January 26, 2026, and is already delivering measurable environmental benefits.

The achievement was showcased through an audio-visual presentation released by Arvind Kumar, Director (Refineries), IndianOil, at the company's Refineries Headquarters in New Delhi.

Developed in collaboration with the Society for Innovation & Entrepreneurship (SINE) at IIT Bombay, the green STP utilizes natural processes involving wetland vegetation, filtration media, and microbial activity to treat sewage. Unlike conventional treatment systems, the technology requires significantly lower energy consumption and generates fewer greenhouse gas emissions.



Arvind Kumar, Director (Refineries), IndianOil, unveils theme posters to mark World Environment Day at Refineries Headquarters in New Delhi

According to IndianOil, the plant's performance over the past four months has demonstrated reduced power usage, near-zero maintenance requirements, and efficient wastewater treatment. The treated water is being reused for horticultural purposes within the refinery premises, supporting the company's broader resource conservation goals.

Encouraged by the successful implementation at Haldia, IndianOil's Refineries Division plans to replicate the model across its refinery network, aiming to scale up environmental benefits and promote sustainable wastewater management practices nationwide.

In another sustainability-focused initiative announced on the occasion, the Refineries

Division launched a pilot programme to recycle end-of-life Inherently Flame Retardant (IFR) suits used by refinery personnel. The project seeks to reduce industrial waste by repurposing used safety apparel, advancing the company's circular economy objectives.

As part of the World Environment Day celebrations, Kumar also unveiled specially designed theme posters aimed at reinforcing environmental awareness and responsibility among employees and stakeholders.

The initiatives underscore IndianOil's ongoing efforts to integrate sustainable technologies and circular economy practices into its refinery operations while contributing to the country's environmental goals.

Goa minister marks 12 years of PM's leadership

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Panji

Tourism and IT Minister Rohan A Khaunte led a series of community service initiatives in Porvorim to commemorate 12 years of Prime Minister Narendra Modi's leadership.

The programme began with a "Swachhata Hi Seva" cleanliness drive at Betim, followed by prayers at Vithoba Rakhumai Temple and Shri Guru Singh Sabha Gurudwara.

Khaunte later partici-



pated in the "Health with Ayurveda | Checked by Doctor 2.0" yoga and wellness session, promoting preventive healthcare. Speaking on the occasion, Khaunte said the milestone reflects PM Modi's dedication to Seva, Swachhata, and Viksit Bharat.

He called upon citizens to contribute to nation-building through collective action and community service. Local leaders, panchayat members, and volunteers actively participated in the events.

Gadkari to visit Shillong on June 15 to attend infra meet, launch national highway projects

TONY DAS ■ Shillong

Union Road Transport and Highways Minister Nitin Gadkari is scheduled to visit Shillong on June 15 to participate in a regional infrastructure summit and launch a series of national highway projects aimed at strengthening connectivity in the Northeast, officials said on Thursday. During his visit, Gadkari will attend the CEOs Round Table at the North East India Infrastructure Summit and Exhibition (NE-INFRA) here, they said.

The summit is expected to bring together policymakers, industry leaders, investors and other stakeholders to discuss infrastructure development, investment opportunities and regional growth in the north-



Nitin Gadkari

eastern states.

According to officials, NE-INFRA 2026 seeks to position the Northeast as an emerging destination for infrastructure investment, with a focus on roads and highways, transport and logistics, urban infrastructure, tourism, energy, digital connectivity and sustainable development.

The minister will also

attend the foundation stone-

laying ceremony for several national highway projects at the Polo Ground in Shillong. The projects are expected to provide a major boost to road connectivity in Meghalaya and the wider northeastern region by facilitating faster movement of goods and passengers, improving access to remote

areas and supporting economic activities. Officials said the highway projects form part of the Centre's broader efforts to strengthen transport infrastructure across the Northeast, which has been identified as a key driver of economic growth, trade, tourism and regional integration.

The expansion and upgradation of the national highway network in the region have significantly improved accessibility over the past few years and are expected to attract greater investment and development opportunities, they said.

The visit comes amid the Centre's continued push to accelerate infrastructure development in the Northeast through enhanced road, rail, air and digital connectivity.

Negligence in implementing farmers' schemes won't be tolerated: Assam Minister Hazarika

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Guwahati

Minister of Agriculture Pijush Hazarika today chaired a high-level review meeting to assess the functioning of the Agriculture Department, taking stock of various Central Government schemes and the challenges faced in their implementation across the state.

Emphasising the need to boost farmer registration for central schemes, the Minister called for an intensive drive to bring more farmers under the ambit of initiatives like PM-KISAN and PM Fasal Bima Yojana. He strongly urged officials to update and expand the state's current figure of 27 lakh registered

farming families, noting that many unregistered families are currently missing out on crucial scheme benefits.

"Horticulture holds the key to multiplying the income of our farmers, who are predominantly engaged in paddy cultivation," Minister Hazarika stated.

To drive this transition, the Minister directed the department to organize a daylong review meeting with the District Agriculture Officers (DAOs) of all 35 districts on June 14 in Guwahati. During this meeting, DAOs will be given specific targets to distribute a total of 15 lakh horticulture saplings to nearly 5 lakh farmers over the next month. Respective MLAs will



also be consulted to help finalize the list of beneficiaries in their constituencies.

Furthermore, the Minister issued a strict warning against the sale of substandard agricultural inputs. He directed the Department to issue a formal warning to all government-licensed Beej Bhandars (seed stockists) to

ensure they only sell quality, certified seeds to farmers. Non-compliant vendors will face immediate blacklisting alongside strict legal action.

Addressing the Agriculture Infrastructure Fund (AIF), Minister Hazarika called for a joint meeting with the Industries Department to align overlapping schemes.

DAILY SUDOKU

			9		7			
							9	5
5				8		4	3	
9	4		2	5				7
	2						6	
8			1	7			5	9
	1	2		9				3
3	9							
		7			8			

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

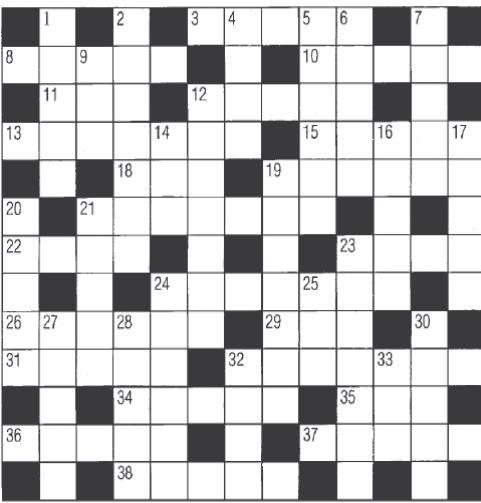
HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.



SOLUTION (11.6.26)								
7	4	3	2	1	6	9	8	5
2	8	1	5	9	7	6	3	4
5	9	6	8	3	4	1	2	7
3	6	7	4	8	9	5	1	2
4	1	9	6	2	5	8	7	3
8	2	5	1	7	3	4	9	6
6	7	8	3	5	1	2	4	9
1	3	4	9	6	2	7	5	8
9	5	2	7	4	8	3	6	1

DOUBLE CROSSWORD FRIDAY | JUNE 12, 2026



ACROSS

- Brother of one of the Seven Sisters? (5)
- The lorry I had was not articulated! (5)
- Bit of a blighter, but no 'heavy' (5)
- Not old enough for a state nurse (3)
- Such a tree no elm could be (5)
- American gentleman in Cheshire? (7)
- Darling invention of J.M. Barrie (5)
- In horticultural hands it has a disturbing effect (3)
- Price rise, possible rip-off, for French fruit (6)
- Holding water, it can make you rich, pet (7)
- Rude thing to call many a reprobate (4)

DOWN

- In a few words, it's a shame being out of breath (5)
- It's shared among the family (7)
- Look to make a new hat out of leather (4)
- Even the best can start falling down (6)
- The thinner the better (5)
- Are they built with axes, possibly? (5)
- A letter, it's said, a horse may understand (3)
- Before modern medicine, they bled (7)
- Drink with a teetotaler out of love (3)
- One's own little place, possibly in part of Chelsea (5)
- Cries out for the old-fashioned vinyl records (5)

- Wherein to browse to quiet music? (4)
- Where Americans pay bills around mid-May (7)
- Structures providing poor shelter? (6)
- A form of fish food (3)
- Cut off during rehearsal maybe? (5)
- Taking the trouble to be thrifty (7)
- New bill about ultimate justice, a legal consideration (5)
- Write a pointed article (3)
- Diminutive underground guard (5)
- Years building an out-of-the way nest (5)
- In place of an enclosure, a tree (5)

- At heart, most important (7)
- What Sadie could give a chap? (5)
- Part taken on board? (5)
- One unconscious of crossing the railroad track? (7)
- Course of a ship touring a great lake (6)
- It's highly exposed during a storm (3)
- One with a broken horn? (5)
- Game for Henry to master (5)
- Amusing? How odd! (5)
- Helps to make the price dear, you'll agree (4)
- A charge that makes you feel robbed of pounds (3)

SOLUTION (11.6.26)		
ACROSS		
1, Laurel	22, Janus	
7, Overture	23, Cone	
8, S-tag	26, Can-a-l	
10, Octa-VIO	28, Rev.	
11, Manual	29, Una-bile	
14, (London)Eye	30, Berate	
16, Kippis	31, Axil	
17, Raps	32, Pres-U-me-s	
19, Vie-le-t	33, Keener	
21, Gaber		

SOLUTION (11.6.26)		
DOWN		
1, Labour	19, Va.-N	
2, Relays	20, Les	
3, Log-O	22, Ja-B	
4, Breaker	23, Cerise	
5, Cut up	24, Oval	
6, Meals	25, Ev-eter	
8, Ste-p	26, Cuppa	
9, Ave	27, Navel	
12, Nit	28, Re-X	
13, Ap-Ron	29, B-sk	
15, Kabul		
18, As-Ian		

PD(1351

Women's T20 WC gets bigger, mirrors changes

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Birmingham

Bigger and more competitive than ever, the ICC T20 Women's World Cup begins here on Friday with the ever-improving India, England and South Africa expected to challenge Australia's traditional dominance in the tournament.

The Aussies, who have won six of the last nine tournaments, will be eager to displace reigning champions New Zealand for a seventh title, but that is no longer a yawn-inducing formality.

The Kiwis themselves are a formidable unit, and then there are India, who landed their maiden global title last year in the 50-over World Cup.

England, strong as ever in home conditions, and South Africa, finalists in the last three ICC events, would be no pushovers either.

In that context, this iteration of the showpiece, beginning with a match here between England and Sri Lanka, is the most open yet in its existence, and it is also the first World Cup in the UK since the first edition in 2009.

The event is also the biggest in terms of the number of participants — 12 — with the addition of Ireland and Netherlands to the mix from 2024.

That expansion itself is a sign of the women's game getting a stronger foothold across nations, but even more satisfying is the development of a level-playing field and the emergence of some raw but exciting talent.

Young talent

It starts with England's Alice Capsey, Tilly Corteen-Coleman and Freya Kemp while their opponents tomorrow, Sri Lanka, field the likes of Vishmi Gunarathne, Iresha Dulani, Kavisha Dilhari and Kawya Kavindi.

New Zealand skipper Amelia Kerr, one of the youngest leaders in the international circuit at 25, is a key player for her side. She is also a heart-touching story of resilience after surviving depression and suicidal



India strong contender to win Women's T20 WC: Reema Malhotra

AMIT ANAND ■ New Delhi

Former cricketer Reema Malhotra believes the Indian women's cricket team is a strong contender to win the upcoming ICC Women's T20 World Cup, largely because of its strong spin bowling resources.

She said the team is brimming with confidence after winning last year's ODI World Cup at home and is no longer dependent on one or two players.

The Women's T20 World Cup will be held in England starting Friday, with the

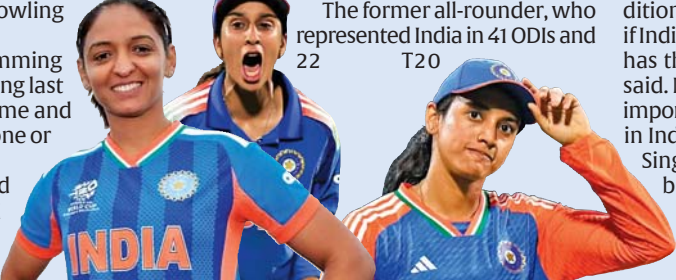
final scheduled for July 5.

"Winning the ODI World Cup has significantly boosted the team's confidence. The players now believe they can perform in any conditions and in any format," Malhotra told 'PTI-Bhasha'.

The former all-rounder, who represented India in 41 ODIs and 22 T20

Internationals, said spinners will play a crucial English conditions.

"Players like Deepti Sharma, Shreyanka Patil, Radha Yadav and Shree Charani will have very important roles. Shafali Verma can also contribute with the ball. The warm conditions are likely to assist spin bowling, and if India's spin attack performs well, the team has the ability to lift the trophy," Malhotra said. Malhotra, however, did not give much importance to the relative lack of experience in India's pace bowling unit. While Renuka Singh Thakur, with 63 T20 Internationals, brings considerable experience, Kranti Goud and Nandini Sharma have played just 11 and three T20 matches. (PTI)



thoughts during the 2020-21 season.

Strong contenders India come with promising N Sree Charani, Yastika Bhatia and Nandani Sharma in their ranks.

The Aussies are still banking on their vet-

erans to reclaim the title, but they also have two exceptional young stars in their ranks — batter Georgina Voll and left-arm seamer Lucy Hamilton.

The Proteas, led by the redoubtable

Laura Wolvaardt, have Kayla Reyneke and Annerie Dercksen leading the march of Next-Gen players, despite bringing back experienced pacer Shabnim Ismail and Dan van Niekerk from retirement.

Afghanistan A prevail over India A by 4 runs



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

■ Dambulla

Afghanistan A caused a major upset by eking out a four-run win over star-studded India A via the Duckworth-Lewis-Stern (DLS) method in a rain-marred tri-nation series match on Thursday.

Batting first, India A posted a daunting 349/9 in a rain-curtailed 49 overs innings, with Prabhsimran Singh leading the charge with a blazing 84 off 69 balls, supported by half-centuries from captain Tilak Varma (66) and Ruturaj Gaikwad (66).

Due to persistent rain intervals, Afghanistan A's target was revised to 294 runs from 38 overs applying the DLS method.

Following an explosive start by captain Imran (75 not out off 70 balls) and Hassan Eisakhil (34 off 29 balls), Afghanistan kept themselves in the hunt. Bahir Shah (51 off 52 balls), then, joined Imran and the duo took them to 177/2 in 25.5 overs when another spell of rain stopped play. At that stage of the game, Afghanistan were found to be four runs ahead of the par score requirement, which sealed their victory.

Raina urges to groom Hardik backup, says Rohit-Kohli's experience vital

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

■ New Delhi

Former batter Suresh Raina believes finding a dependable backup for injury-prone all-rounder Hardik Pandya should be a priority for India ahead of the 2027 ODI World Cup, while also stressing the importance of veterans Rohit Sharma and Virat Kohli in supporting captain Shubman Gill.

Speaking on JioStar's 'Follow the Blues', Raina said India's preparations for the next World Cup must include developing alternatives to Hardik, whose recurring fitness issues remain a concern. "Hardik Pandya has had several injury setbacks, which is a concern. By the time the next ODI World Cup arrives, India must have a reliable backup for him," Raina said.

Raina identified Nitish Kumar Reddy as a promising option, saying the



young all-rounder has made significant strides in both departments. "His batting has become more solid. He bowled with good pace and control in the IPL, and his fitness has also held up well. The team management will need to

manage his workload carefully and give him consistent opportunities," he said.

The former left-hander also backed Rohit and Kohli to play a crucial role in India's World Cup campaign, saying their experience in high-pressure ICC events would be invaluable for Gill. "Both are proven run-scorers in ICC World Cups. They have won ICC trophies and know how to handle pressure in knockout games. For Shubman Gill, captaining India in a World Cup, having Rohit and Virat alongside him will be a huge advantage," Raina said.



WPL, ODI World created unstoppable force in Indian cricket: Nasser Hussain

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

■ Mumbai

The arrival of the Women's Premier League in 2023 and a title win in the Women's ODI World Cup has produced an "unstoppable force" in Indian cricket which will increase the depth, former England skipper said Nasser Hussain on Thursday.

India clinched their maiden ICC title late in 2025 winning the Women's ODI World Cup and a significant amount of credit for the team's success was given to the T20 competition which brought about tectonic changes in women's cricket in India.

Hussain believes the combination of the two has already become unstoppable and Indian cricket stands to benefit in the longer run. "It's unstop-

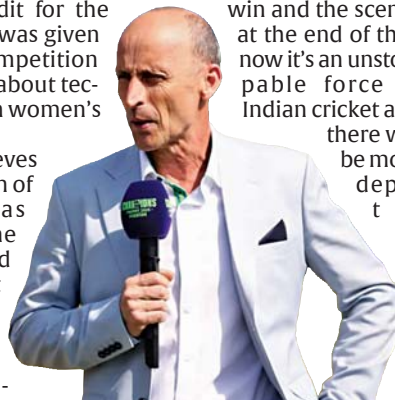


pable now in the women's, that combination of the WPL and the 50-overs World Cup win and the scenes at the end of that, now it's an unstoppable force in Indian cricket and there will be more depth to

the players coming through," Hussain told reporters on JioStar Media Day.

"The biggest thing for me is depth. We're trying to work out (the best combination) in that squad now, and obviously they're missing two (players) as well because of injuries. Two very good players, Amanjot (Kaur) in particular," he said.

Hussain said Indian Women's team was reliant on a few players in the past but the recent years have seen the team's superstars coming under pressure with others knocking on door.



Dravid lauds KSCA T20 cricket's role



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Bengaluru

Former India skipper Rahul Dravid on Thursday termed the upcoming Maharaja Trophy KSCA T20 tournament as a fine platform for the young state players to showcase their talent, which can open the door to the lucrative Indian Premier League.

The latest edition of the tournament will be played across Mysuru, Hubballi and Bengaluru from June 20 to July 12.

"Having myself been involved in the IPL for many years, I know for a fact that it is a tournament that is followed by a lot of IPL teams. There will be scouts who come to the games live, but many of them watch it on television as well," Dravid said after unveiling the trophy. "The scores, statistics and data from these matches are watched very closely and it really helps a lot of these players get into the IPL," he added.

Dravid cited the example of Rajasthan Royals leg-spinner Yash Raj Punja, who hails from Karnataka.

Wahab wants Pakistan women to play attacking cricket in T20 WC

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Karachi

Pakistan women's team head coach Wahab Riaz has insisted that his side will not compromise on playing an attacking brand of cricket during the T20 World Cup in England, beginning Friday.

Former Pakistan Test fast bowler Wahab said his players have been told to enjoy the occasion, express themselves and focus on playing their natural game despite being placed in a challenging group.



"It is the dream of every player to play in a World Cup. I have told my players to go out there, enjoy themselves, express themselves and play attacking cricket,



no matter what the outcome is," Wahab said in a statement.

Pakistan are grouped alongside arch-rivals India, defending champions Australia, South

Africa, Netherlands and Bangladesh, but Wahab said the team is targeting a place in the semifinals.

The former pacer said the

team's recent struggles had provided valuable experience ahead of the tournament.

"Despite the results, the players have gained exposure by playing in Ireland and in the warm-up games before the World Cup. The weather is quite different from Pakistan and the pitches also behave differently, but the players have been told not to worry and just play their natural game," he said.

Wahab added that the unpredictable nature of T20 cricket gives every team a chance.

First in six decades: India born Nikhil added to Oz's T20 squad



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Sydney

Spin bowling all-rounder Nikhil Chaudhary, who holds Permanent Residency here, on Thursday became the first Indian-born male player in over six decades to feature in Australia's cricket squad when he was named in the T20 side for the upcoming away series against Bangladesh.

The three-match series will be held in Chattogram from June 17 to 21. Chaudhary has been playing for JB Bruges in the EUT20 competition in Belgium and was with the Delhi Capitals in the recent IPL. He will join Australia's white-ball outfits in Dhaka on Friday. "The panel has been impressed by his BBL form, particularly last season, leading to his addition to the squad," selector Tony Dodemaide was quoted as saying by cricket.com.au.

BCCI names India U-19 squads for Sri Lanka tour

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

■ New Delhi

The BCCI's Junior Cricket Committee on Thursday picked the India Men's Under-19 squads for the upcoming tour of Sri Lanka, comprising three one-day matches and two multi-day games.

Yashbhardhan Singh Chauhan will lead the one-day and multi-day teams, with Lakshya Raichandani named vice-captain in both squads. The one-day squad includes wicketkeepers Rajat Baghel and Anvay Dravid, while Manav



Krishna and Aryan Sandesh Sakpal have been picked as wicketkeepers for the multi-day fixtures.

Former India captain Rahul Dravid's son, Anvay Dravid, also features in the one-day squad.